ILLINOIS

Graduate College Handbook 2026–2027

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About the Handbook

The Graduate College Handbook contains policies applicable to the graduate community at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. This handbook is current for the 2026-2027 academic year. A full printable page is also available. Handbooks from previous years can be accessed in our archives.

Preface

Graduate students at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign are enrolled in the Graduate College. With oversight over graduate programs in more than 100 disciplinary areas, the Graduate College fosters a vibrant campus community of scholars. The Graduate College awards doctoral degrees, master's degrees, Certificates of Advanced Study, Artist's Diplomas, and Graduate Certificates. The Graduate College does not award the Juris Doctor (JD) degree, the Medical Doctor (MD) degree, and the Doctor of Veterinary Medicine (DVM) degree.

Part A of this handbook covers academic policies and requirements pertaining to graduate students. All graduate students must follow Graduate College policies. Individual graduate programs may have additional policies specific to their students. Therefore, students should familiarize themselves with policies in their departmental handbook as well as those outlined here. Additionally, graduate students must also be aware of campus and university policies as well as state laws that could impact graduate students but are not under the jurisdiction or authority of the Graduate College.

Part B of this handbook contains the administrative policy for program, units and staff. Unlike the student section of the handbook this section may be updated at any time during the year, and becomes effective immediately, unless otherwise noted. The Graduate College reviews all new and revised courses that carry graduate credit as well as graduate programs that lead to a graduate-level credential, as part of its statutory function to "develop and safeguard standards of graduate work." This section will be archived annually, but faculty and staff should always use the current version when seeking administrative policy.

The Graduate College works closely with individual graduate students, faculty, and staff to provide support at all stages of graduate education from admissions through thesis deposit and degree certification. More information about the Graduate College is online at www.grad.illinois.edu.

Terms Used Throughout this Handbook

- “department” or “unit” may refer to a program, school, institute, or similar type of academic unit
- “fellowships” and “fellows” include traineeships and trainees except where specified
- “students” refers to graduate students
- “term” and “semester” are used interchangeably
- “thesis” may refer to a thesis or a dissertation

Recent Changes to Graduate College Policy

The changes outlined below begin with the 2026-2027 academic year. Previous versions of the handbook are available on the Graduate College website.

Policy Affected	Effective Date	Explanation/Notes
4.2 Graduation Requirements	Fall 2026	Adjusted policy to make departmental format review of a thesis or dissertation optional.

Chapter 1
Admission to the Graduate College

Students must apply to and be admitted to the Graduate College through the standard admission process. Students may or may not be degree-seeking, and admission procedures differ based on this distinction. Except in the case of non-degree admission, students may only be admitted to the Graduate College if first approved and referred for admission by the academic program of study. Admission procedures and policies also differ depending on whether an applicant is defined as a domestic or international applicant.

Defining Applicants as International or Domestic

Domestic Applicants Domestic applicants are citizens or lawful permanent residents of the United States, or have been granted Asylee, Refugee or Paroled in the Public Interest status by the United States government. Domestic applicants are required to submit the domestic application fee. Lawful Permanent Residents are also required to upload a copy of their Permanent Resident Card (Green Card) directly to the online application. For applicants who have submitted an application but have not yet been approved for United States Permanent Residency, please see the instructions for International applicants.

International Applicants International applicants are citizens or permanent residents of a country other than the United States to which they intend to return. International applicants may be in the United States on an educational, worker, or visitor visa, or be residing in their home country. International applicants are required to submit the international application fee. International applicants who are requesting F-1 or J-1 visa eligibility documents are also required to provide evidence of financial support.

1.1 Graduate Admission Policies

Applicants apply to an academic program using the online system and the instructions provided by the home academic unit and the Graduate College. Programs may set additional application requirements, and deadlines will vary by unit. Applicants should consult with the desired program offices for details. Programs will review the application first and may either deny admission or recommend admission to the Graduate College. The Graduate College will then review and grant official admission to the university if the applicant meets the Graduate College minimum requirements. Applicants may not apply to a program in which they already hold a similar degree (see Chapter 4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements for details.) The Graduate College requires all applicants to submit these materials with the online application:

- Online Graduate Application,
- Academic credentials from all post-secondary institutions attended,
- Application fee. The non-refundable application fee amount is determined by citizenship status. Payment may be made online via credit card. An application cannot be processed until the application fee has been submitted or an application fee waiver has been approved. A change in desired term of entry may require a second application and application fee to be assessed.

Most graduate programs will also require additional materials to be submitted with the graduate application, such as an academic and/or personal statement, resume, and letters of recommendation. These requirements will vary by program and applicants should consult the requirements listed on their proposed program of study websites.

Graduate Admissions Deadline Policy

The Graduate College application and admissions deadline is the tenth day of classes for each admission term. Graduate departments may apply earlier deadlines for each term for those applying to their degree programs. However, applications received by the Graduate College after the tenth day of classes will be reviewed on a case-by-case basis considering both the applicant's credentials and the departmental justification for the late admission.

Admissions Deferral Policy

An applicant for graduate admission who wishes to change the desired term of entry either before or after receiving a notice of admission must contact the admitting department to request the change. If the applicant is requesting to defer the entry term for more than one year, a second application fee will be required by the Graduate College.

1.2 Minimum Requirements for Admission

The following are the minimum requirements for admission into the Graduate College:

- Applicants must have earned at least a bachelor's degree from a regionally accredited college in the United States or a comparable degree from a recognized institution of higher learning abroad. A grade point average (GPA) of 3.0 (A=4.0), or comparable GPA for an international applicant, for the last two years of undergraduate study is a minimum requirement for admission. If an applicant's undergraduate study is longer than four years, additional semesters may be used to calculate the admission GPA. Please note that proposed programs of study may require a higher GPA than the Graduate College's minimum standard.

- Applicants enrolled in the final year of a bachelor's degree from an accredited college in the United States or a comparable degree program from a recognized institution of higher learning abroad, and who meet the GPA requirements stated above will be admitted conditionally pending receipt of final academic credentials showing the undergraduate degree as conferred.
- International applicants must meet minimum requirements based on their country of origin. Please note that proposed programs of study may require a higher GPA than the Graduate College's minimum standard.

A student who does not meet one or more of the admission requirements:

- may be approved for admission with limited status with support from the academic program and approval from the Graduate College.
- may qualify for full status admission based on a master's degree from a regionally accredited college in the United States or a comparable graduate degree from a recognized institution of higher learning abroad with an acceptable cumulative graduate GPA of 3.0 (A=4.0), or comparable GPA for an international applicant.
- may qualify for full status admission after completion of a minimum of 12 credit hours as a non-degree student at the graduate level within the proposed academic major at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign and received a cumulative GPA that meets the department minimum for good standing.
- may qualify for full status admission with support from the academic program and approval from the Graduate College if they have completed 10+ years of professional work experience in the field corresponding to the proposed academic major.

Official Academic Credentials

Applicants must list in their online application each institution of post-secondary education from which they have earned credit. Applicants must also upload to the online application their transcript/academic record (and diplomas or certificates of degrees if the degree is awarded and not listed on the transcript) for each of these institutions.

All credentials uploaded to the online application are considered unofficial. An applicant will only be asked to submit official credentials (transcripts, academic records, diplomas, certificates of degrees, etc.,) if they are admitted. These must be submitted during the first term of enrollment at the university in order to continue beyond the first term.

The university reserves the right to require official academic credentials at any time during the admissions process, and to rescind any offer of admission made if discrepancies between unofficial and official transcript(s) are found. (See section 1-303 of the Student Code for additional information.)

English Proficiency Requirements for Admission

Domestic Applicants. Proof of English proficiency is not required for admission for domestic applicants. Some domestic applicants may be required to demonstrate proof of spoken English if applying for a teaching assistantship. Please review the English proficiency requirements for teaching assistants.

International Applicants. All international degree-seeking applicants are required to submit the results of an accepted test as evidence of English proficiency unless they qualify for an exemption. Official scores are required to be submitted directly from the testing agency. All scores must be dated within two years of the beginning of the proposed admission term.

Acceptable tests and corresponding minimum scores are available on the Graduate College website. A student who does not meet the English proficiency requirement for admission may be admitted on limited status and be required to take the English as a Second Language Placement Test (EPT) prior to enrolling at Illinois.

English Proficiency Requirement Exemptions

Applicants who meet one of the following criteria are exempt from the English proficiency requirement for admission:

- Received a post-secondary degree from a U.S. institution (or an institution within an approved country) within five years of the proposed admission term.
- Completion of at least two years of post-secondary study in the U.S. (or an approved country) within five years of the proposed term of initial enrollment.
- Completion of at least two years of professional work experience in the U.S. (or an approved country) within five years of the proposed term of initial enrollment.

Approved Countries with English as the Primary Language

Illinois Graduate Admissions recognizes the following countries as having English as the primary language: Australia, Bahamas, Barbados, Belize, Bermuda, Canada, Dominica, Fiji, Gambia, Ghana, Grenada, Guyana, Ireland, Jamaica, Kenya, Lesotho, Malawi, New Zealand, Nigeria, Philippines, Scotland, Sierra Leone, Singapore, South Africa, St. Kitts, Trinidad & Tobago, Uganda, United Kingdom, United States, and Zimbabwe.

English Proficiency for Teaching Assistants

Please note that all English proficiency requirements and exemptions listed above are for admission purposes only. Admissions minimums are not equivalent to minimums required for holding a teaching assistantship; and not

all exemptions apply for those holding a teaching assistantship. For more information, please see the English Proficiency Requirement for Graduate Teaching Assistants.

1.3 Non-Degree Applicants

Applicants may seek admission to the University of Illinois as a graduate non-degree student with or without a specific graduate department assigned. A bachelor's degree is required for all graduate non-degree applicants. For general non-degree graduate students (those without a specific department assigned), applications are accepted for fall, spring, and summer terms. Graduate departments may set additional requirements and also determine deadlines and term availability for department-specific non-degree applicants.

Note: International exchange non-degree students must follow the application and admissions policies of degree-seeking applicants.

1.4 Admission Status

A student is admitted to the Graduate College on full status or limited status and classified as a degree-seeking or non-degree student. The admission status is stated in the notice of admission letter. Students must have full graduate standing and be degree-seeking in order to be awarded a graduate degree.

Full Status

A student who meets all admission requirements set by the Graduate College may be approved for full status admission. However, if the admitting graduate program wishes to admit the student on limited status due to departmental deficiencies, the Graduate College will admit on limited status even if all normal minimum requirements are met.

Limited Status

A student who does not meet one or more of the admission requirements may be approved for limited status admission. Students must be in good standing by addressing all requirements in order to be awarded a graduate degree. There are different types of limited status:

- **Limited status due to a lack of demonstrated English language proficiency.** Students admitted with limited status due to lack of demonstrated English language proficiency will be required to take the English as a Second Language Placement Test (EPT) at the beginning of their first term of enrollment. The

results of this test may satisfy this requirement or indicate that the student is required to complete additional English as a Second Language courses. The student must complete those required courses during their first year following enrollment at the university.

- **Limited status due to low GPA or no comparable bachelor's degree.** Students are admitted on limited status and must meet their program's minimum GPA requirements by the end of the first semester.

Non-Degree Status

There are a number of restrictions and conditions that apply to non-degree status. A non-degree student:

- may only receive an assistantship appointment if the non-degree status is a result of an exchange agreement that includes an appointment in the terms of the agreement or a petition to hold the assistantship is approved (one semester appointments only);
- is not eligible for financial aid administered by the Graduate College, such as fellowships and conference travel awards;
- must reapply for admission and pay the application fee if they wish to become a degree-seeking student;
- is limited to taking fewer than 12 hours per fall or spring semester (fewer than 6 hours in the summer), which means they are not considered to be full-time for most purposes; exceptions are BTAA Traveling Scholars and international students participating in special exchange programs for which full-time approval has been obtained from the Graduate College prior to admission;
- may have limits on transferring credit if subsequently admitted to and enrolled in a degree program.

> Non-degree students are encouraged to review Chapter 2.2 Course Loads and Chapter 3.3 Transfer of Credit.

1.5 Re-Entry

Students who do not enroll for a calendar year must apply for re-entry.

Students requesting re-entry and to enroll in their previous department may be allowed to apply for reentry via the petition process. Some departments require students to complete a full application with all required materials; however, the application fee will be waived for these students. Students should contact their department for instructions. Re-entry must be approved by the department and the Graduate College.

Students requesting re-entry and to enroll in a new graduate department must submit a full graduate application with all required application materials and an application fee. Re-entry must be approved by the new proposed program of study and the Graduate College.

Regardless of the re-entry process used, the Graduate College will reassess a student's residency status for tuition and assessment purposes upon re-entry. In addition, if a student has attended another postsecondary institution since their last enrollment term, they will be required to provide this information and submit official transcripts from any degree-granting institution.

Chapter 2
Registration

There are three academic terms in each academic year: fall, spring, and summer. Graduate-level courses are assigned 400- and 500-level course numbers. Some 600- and 700-level courses are also approved for graduate credit.

Students must register online using the Self-Service registration system by the tenth day of instruction.

Students are responsible for registering, ensuring the accuracy of their schedules, and meeting campus deadlines. Students who find errors in their schedules should immediately correct these errors. Corrections must be completed before the deadline for adding or dropping a course.

Students should note that changes to registration-including dropping or adding courses, withdrawal, or cancellation-should be considered carefully as these changes may impact tuition assessment, financial aid, waiver eligibility, and other important aspects of student standing. Complete registration information can be found at the Registrar's website. In particular, the section on registration procedures includes information on time tickets (the earliest date and time a student can enroll for a future semester), eligibility to register, holds, enrollment requirements and prerequisites, “authorization only” courses, credit-no credit, canceling registration, and withdrawal (including refund deadlines).

2.1 General Information About Registration

Students must enroll during their term of admission. Admission for a term must be requested and granted by the Graduate College by the tenth day of class. Approvals for late admission will be granted based on applicant merit and departmental justification. If enrollment in that term is not possible, students should contact their graduate program to request their admission term be changed. Students are expected to be enrolled for fall and spring semesters throughout their graduate program, and students must be admitted to the degree program and enrolled in the program for at least one term after admission, which could be spring, summer, or fall in order to graduate from the program (see Chapter 4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements for more information). Fellowship and traineeship recipients must be enrolled during the terms of their appointments. Students with assistantships for spring or fall must be enrolled during the term in which they are appointed. See Chapter 8 Assistantships and Fellowships for information about summer appointments and assistantship policies.

International Students

International students on F-1 and J-1 student visas must register for full-time enrollment in every fall and spring term and must register by the tenth day of instruction to comply with Student Exchange and Visitor Information System (SEVIS) requirements. International students registered in on-campus programs require the prior approval of International Student and Scholar Services to drop below full-time enrollment, and they should see the explanation of full-time status in this handbook (see Chapter 2.2 Course Loads) for more information.

2.2 Course Loads

Full-Time Enrollment

Graduate students may be required to maintain full-time enrollment; however, what constitutes full-time enrollment can vary. For example, departmental requirements, eligibility for student loans or other financial aid, fellowships, certain types of non-university insurance policies, or tax requirements may use different definitions of full-time enrollment. Students are responsible for understanding what requirements apply to them.

For all students.

- The Student Code contains the university definition of full-time status for students.
- Simultaneous enrollment at another institution may not be added to hours enrolled at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign in order to determine full-time status.
- Audited courses do not count as any hours toward load.
- For purposes of loan deferral only, 0 credit registration in GC 599 will count as full-time registration.
- Graduate student employees with assistantship appointments who are not registered for at least a half-time load in a particular term will be subject to Social Security and Medicare deductions from the assistantship pay for that term

International students. International students are considered by the Graduate College to be enrolled full-time when they meet the requirements as follows:

- International students on an F-1 or J-1 visa are required to maintain full-time enrollment for purposes of Student Exchange and Visitor Information System (SEVIS) reporting. Students who are required to take English as a Second Language (ESL) classes as a result of the English Placement Test (EPT) or because of teaching assistantship obligations. For purposes of load calculation, ESL courses required or recommended by the EPT will count as four hours even if the registration is listed in the student registration systems as zero hours.

- International students whose first term of study is the summer term must carry a full course load.
- Continuing international students are not required by the campus to enroll for the summer terms, although their departments may require enrollment. Those who do enroll do not need to carry a full course load for SEVIS purposes.
- International graduate students who have completed all credit requirements (course work and thesis research) for their degree programs may register for 0 hours of 599 until completion of study. This registration will be considered full-time for purposes of SEVIS reporting. International students seeking this exception to the full-time credit requirements should contact Office of International Student and Scholar Services before registering for the reduced credit load.

Minimum Enrollment

All students should keep in mind that enrollment below a full-time course of study may jeopardize progress toward a degree, financial aid, fellowship, loan deferment, or the visa status of an international student. Some departments have established a minimum amount of credit for which their students must register.

Maximum Enrollment

The maximum amount of credit in which a graduate student may enroll is 20 hours in fall and spring terms and 12 hours in the summer term. Students in non-degree status have other restrictions, and can see Chapter 2.1 General Information About Registration for more information.

Definition of a Credit Hour

According to the Federal Credit Hour Definition: A credit hour is an amount of work represented in intended learning outcomes and verified by evidence of student achievement that is an institutionally established equivalency that reasonably approximates not less than:

1. one hour of classroom or direct faculty instruction and a minimum of two hours of out-of-class student work each week for approximately fifteen weeks for one semester or trimester hour of credit, or ten to twelve weeks for one quarter hour of credit, or the equivalent amount of work over a different amount of time; or
2. at least an equivalent amount of work as required in paragraph (1) of this definition for other activities as established by an institution, including laboratory work, internships, practica, studio work, and other academic work leading to the award of credit hours.

It is customary for graduate courses that carry either 3 or 4 hours of credit to meet in organized instruction for 43 to 58 **contact hours** per term (3 to 4 contact hours per week in fall or spring) including examinations.

2.3 Registration Deadlines and Holds

Deadlines

The deadlines for students to add and drop classes vary depending on the length of the class (e.g., full semester or part of term) and the term. The last time to submit changes to a student's current term registration is 5:00 p.m. on Reading Day. Summer deadlines vary; see the Graduate College Academic Calendar for details.

Add deadlines. After the tenth day of instruction, students who wish to register or add a course must complete a Late Registration/Late Course Change form. The student's registration or course add must be approved by the faculty member offering the course, indicated by the faculty member's signature on the form. Students must also obtain approval on the Late Registration form from their academic program, and the enrolling department must also indicate its approval. Forms must be submitted to the Graduate College for final review and completion of the request.

Holds

Holds can be placed on a student's record for several reasons. Most commonly these include departmental deficiencies, immunization requirements, disciplinary reasons, financial encumbrance to the university, lack of academic progress, failure to submit transcripts, or low GPA. Holds may prohibit the student from making changes to their registration, from receiving a transcript, or from graduating. Holds will appear in the Registration section of a student's Self-Service profile.

> QUESTIONS
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> about registration load and loan deferment should consult their lenders (school, bank, or loan agency). Students may also contact the Office of Student Financial Aid for advice or referral to the appropriate office or agency.
>
> about certification of full-time status should contact the Office of the Registrar.
>
> about the requirements of specific academic programs should be directed to the graduate office for that program.
>
> about their fellowships or traineeships should consult the Graduate College Fellowship Office or the funding agency.

> about full-time enrollment for international students on visas should contact the Office of International Student and Scholar Services.

2.4 Registration Options

In Absentia Registration

In absentia is a registration type designed for students in on-campus programs who wish or need to remain registered, but plan to be studying or doing research for at least one semester at least fifty miles away from campus. In absentia registration is not permitted for students enrolled in courses meeting on campus. Students may register in absentia for any number of credit hours. There is no decrease in tuition rates when a student is registered in absentia, and tuition assessment will be based on the student's college and program, their residency status, and the number of hours for which the student is registered.

In absentia registration, however, recognizes that such students do not access the full range of campus services and resources while away. Therefore, students registered in absentia are only assessed the general fee. Payment of the general fee provides students with access to their university e-mail and access to library services. Because students are not assessed other fees, they are not eligible for services associated with those fees. For example, if students registered in absentia wish to have health insurance, they must make alternative arrangements.

A student must submit a form to the Graduate College to request in absentia registration. In absentia requests are only accepted for the current/upcoming term and must be submitted by the tenth day of classes. Students must be registered using Self-Service prior to submitting the request.

Zero Hours Registration

Graduate students who have completed all degree requirements except the thesis or dissertation may consider registering for 0 hours of research credit. It is important for such students to consider the implications of not being a full-time student (see Chapter 2.2 Course Loads for more information).

Graduate College (GC) 599

GC 599 is a 0 credit hour registration option for advanced doctoral students who do not have any financial assistance (such as an assistantship, fellowship, etc.) that would cover their tuition and fees for the semester, however they must maintain full-time enrollment to defer student loans.

To be eligible to register for GC 599, a student must:

- have a guaranteed student loan that would require immediate repayment if the student were not registered for the minimum credit required by the lender to defer the loan;
- have passed the preliminary examination prior to the term in which they wish to register for GC 599;
- have completed all Graduate College and departmental requirements for the degree except for completing the dissertation, defending, and depositing;
- not have any financial assistance that would cover tuition and fees; and
- complete and submit the appropriate form to the Graduate College by the tenth day of classes.

Students who are required to complete a mandatory internship as part of their degree requirements may also register for GC 599 provided they comply with all points above except for completing the dissertation, defending, and depositing.

Students enrolled in GC 599 for 0 credits are assessed tuition and campus fees based on 0 credit hours.

Study Away

Big Ten Academic Alliance (CIC) 500. This registration option is used with the Traveling Scholar Program, which allows doctoral students to utilize special class offerings, laboratory facilities, or work on an independent study at a participating BTAA institution. Registration is limited to two semesters per BTAA policy.

Graduate College (GC) 498. Registration in GC 498 is to be used when studying at another U. S. institution. For registration procedures, students must contact the unit on this campus through which they are studying. Units then forward the registration request to the Graduate College for approval and processing. See the Course Catalog for more information.

Graduate College (GC) 499. Registration in GC 499 is to be used when studying abroad. For registration procedures, students must contact the unit on this campus through which they are studying. The unit will then forward the registration request to the Graduate College for approval and processing. See the Course Catalog for more information.

Audit

An auditor is only a listener in the classes attended; they are not a participant in any part of the exercises. Auditors are not permitted in studio, laboratory, or activity courses. An audited course will appear on the student's transcript with a grade of AU. Audited hours do not count toward assessed hours. An audited course does not count toward the registration requirement for fellows. A course, once audited, may not be repeated for graduate credit.

Students wishing to audit a class must make the request using an Auditor's Permit form. The student should take this form to the first class meeting and ask the instructor to sign, indicating approval. The form should then be submitted to the Graduate College for approval. Approval from both the instructor and the Graduate College is required. The deadline for submitting the Auditor's Permit form to the Graduate College is the tenth day of instruction in the fall and spring terms. See the Graduate College Academic Calendar for summer term deadlines. Students who are registered for less than 12 hours, not including the audited course, who do not have a tuition waiver will be charged a $15 audit fee.

Credit-No Credit

Credit-no credit is a permanent notation on the academic record that may be requested by a student with approval from the academic department. Grades for study abroad and transfer credit are also designated on the transcript as credit-no credit.

Only students in good academic standing and full status admission are allowed to register for credit-no credit course work.

Students are advised to check the Class Schedule to be sure that the course desired is graded using a standard letter grade mode. Courses set up with S/U grading mode may not be taken for credit-no credit.

In any one semester, a student may take no more than 4 semester hours on a credit-no credit basis, except in these cases:

- students registering for Study Abroad or Domestic Study Away, or
- students enrolling in one five-hour undergraduate language course.

Over the entire degree program, a student must earn at least two hours of graded (A-D) course work for each hour of credit-no credit course work.

The form to request credit-no credit notation must be completed and submitted to the Graduate College before the deadline published in the Graduate College Academic Calendar. After the request is approved and processed, the letter grade reported by the instructor will change to the credit-no credit notation as follows. A grade of D- or better are required to earn credit.

> Tuition and Fees
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> The Office of the Registrar's website has information about tuition ranges based on your registration.

> For more information, consult: registrar.illinois.edu.

A student may amend a credit-no credit request and return to a regular grade mode by filing a second credit-no credit form and submitting it by the published deadline as indicated in the Graduate College Academic Calendar. Additional information about credit-no credit can be found in the Student Code.

2.5 Academic Leave of Absence

Academic Leaves of Absence

An academic leave of absence is used when a student will not enroll for one or more semesters. An academic leave of absence may be used for a variety of reasons, including but not limited to, health reasons, personal reasons, active military service, or dependent or family care responsibilities. Students who are on an approved academic leave of absence are not expected to make progress on the degree. In addition, students on academic leaves of absence should not expect that faculty will provide feedback on academic work, including proposals or drafts of theses.

Enrolled students who need to take time away after the semester has begun are not eligible for academic leaves of absence. Students should consult with their program on academic and registration options and human resources regarding employment leave options.

Students must document their request for a leave by filing a Leave of Absence Request form. Students who anticipate not being enrolled for one or more terms, (fall or spring semesters, not summer), for whatever reason should meet with their program adviser before the first day of classes of their period of non-enrollment to request an academic leave of absence.

Timing and Limits

All academic leaves should be requested before the term begins and cannot be approved for a term in which the student had registered and withdrawn. An academic leave of absence cannot be requested for a previous term.

Students are eligible for a two terms of academic leaves of absence (spring or fall semesters) during a student's degree program. These terms may be consecutive or approved individually. In exceptional circumstances a student may, upon submitting a petition, receive approval for additional academic leave after exhausting the two initial terms.

When an enrolled student withdraws from the current term, this term will not be counted towards an academic leave of absence.

Degree Time Limits

An approved academic leave of absence extends the Graduate College time limits for completion of the preliminary examination and the time to degree by the number of approved leave terms (up to a maximum of two terms).

If the student's time to degree will have expired by the start of their academic leave, then they will need to petition for a time extension when requesting the academic leave of absence.

Summer-only Graduate Programs

Students who are enrolled in summer only programs must apply for a leave of absence before taking a summer term off. Students in summer only programs are eligible for two summer terms of leave.

Re-Entry after Leave of Absence

At the time their leave of absence is approved, students will be approved to re-enter the same graduate program for the designated term following their leave.

Procedures to Request a Leave of Absence

Requests for a leave of absence should be approved by the student's academic department prior to the first day of classes. To request a formal academic leave the student should complete the Request for Academic Leave of Absence form before the first day of classes of the term of non-enrollment.

> Graduate Students who leave the university at any time should refer to the Student Code Sections 3-308, 3-312, and 3-313 for additional information.

Absent Without Leave Policy

Degree seeking graduate students are required to request a formal academic leave of absence before not being enrolled for one or more terms, (fall/spring, not summer). Students in summer-only programs are required to request a formal academic leave of absence before taking a summer term off from their enrollment. There are potentially negative consequences for failing to request an academic leave of absence. Students who do not enroll and do not meet with the program and document their status with an approved academic leave of absence before a period of non-enrollment are considered absent without leave. A program may put an advising hold on a

student who is absent without leave. A student who is absent without leave may be prevented from reenrolling, may have additional degree requirements to complete if allowed to return, or may be subject to new degree requirements.

Chapter 3
Academic Record

Our campus operates on a semester system and all course credit is measured in semester hours. A student's academic record will reflect all courses and grades for which they enrolled. However, it is important to note that some courses are not approved for graduate credit, and would not count towards degree requirements. Courses at the 500-level are approved for graduate credit, and some 400-, 600-, and 700-level courses are also approved for graduate credit. Please refer to the Class Schedule for details on individual courses.

3.1 Grades and Grading System

Details of the grading system in use are found in the Student Code.

Course Grades

Grades and the points used in the computation of grade point averages are found in the table on the next page.

A grade of F may be assigned to courses dropped for academic irregularities. A grade of F is assigned when an I (Incomplete) grade or DFR (Defer) in a non-thesis course grade is not replaced with a permanent grade by the deadline. See DFR and I below for more information.

In addition to assigned grades that are included in the computation of Grade Point Average (GPA), the following notations may be used, but are not included in computation of GPA: AU, CR/NC, DFR, I, NR, NV, S/U, W.

- **AU:** Audit; indicates attendance as a visitor only.
- **CR /NC:** Credit-No credit earned.
- **DFR:** Grade deferred. To be used only in courses that extend over more than one semester excluding 599 research credit. The grade must be converted to a permanent grade no later than 5:00 p.m. on Reading Day of the next semester in which the student is registered. If no grade change is submitted within that period, the DFR will be converted as follows: for letter graded courses to an F, for courses graded Satisfactory/Unsatisfactory to a U, and for courses taken on Credit/No Credit basis to an NC.
- **I:** Incomplete. A grade of "incomplete" may be assigned at the discretion of the instructor of the course to allow an extension of time to satisfy final exam requirements or other final course requirements. The period of time allowed to finish remaining course requirements will be set by the instructor and communicated to the student upon assignment of the I grade. The instructor may authorize such extension of time for a graduate student regardless of the level of the course. If no final grade is assigned

by the deadlines described below the grade becomes an F (or U) by rule, depending on grading mode of the course. Reasonable extensions of time are granted by the Graduate College for justifiable reasons. A student will not be certified for a degree with an Incomplete grade on the academic record.

  - I grades assigned in fall will become an F (or U) by rule after Reading Day in the spring.
  - I grades assigned in spring will become an F (or U) by rule after the tenth day of instruction in the following fall semester.
  - I grades assigned in the summer will become an F (or U) by rule after Reading Day in the fall.

- **NR:** Not reported. This temporary notation is automatically entered if an instructor does not report a grade by the deadline. A student will not be certified for a degree with an NR notation in the academic record.
- **NV:** Not valid. This temporary notation is used when an instructor reports a grade in a mode that has not been approved for use with that course.
- **S /U:** Satisfactory/Unsatisfactory. A permanent notation used as a final grade only in courses (generally thesis research or seminar courses) approved for this grade mode.
- **W:** Approved late course drop or term withdrawal without credit.

Minimum Grades and Credit for Repeated Courses

The Graduate College has no minimum grade policy, but a department or program may set a minimum grade to be earned in order for a course to count as credit toward the degree. Students are responsible for knowing their

departmental requirements. The program determines whether hours for repeated courses count toward the degree. When a graduate student repeats a course, all hours and grades count toward the cumulative graduate GPA.

3.2 Academic Standing

Graduate students must maintain a minimum GPA and make satisfactory progress in all other aspects of their degree programs in order to continue as students. Academic standing reflects the student's level of accomplishment with regard to these aspects. The Graduate College monitors cumulative and semester graduate GPA and time limits, and graduate programs monitor all other aspects of academic progress. There are three categories of academic standing: Good academic standing, academic warning (not in good academic standing), and dropped.

Minimum GPA

Campus policy requires a student to maintain a minimum cumulative graduate GPA of 2.75 and a semester GPA of 2.25 in order to continue in an advanced degree program, and to have a cumulative graduate GPA of at least 2.75 to graduate. Many departments, however, require a higher for the cumulative graduate GPA. The Graduate College enforces the department's minimum based on the calculated graduate cumulative GPA. Students enrolled in joint degree programs must meet the minimum GPA requirements of both degree programs in order to maintain satisfactory academic progress and to graduate.

Minimum GPA requirements by program. All graduate students must meet the minimum degree GPA specified by their degree program in order to have the degree certified and to graduate. Students admitted in an earlier term may have a different requirement. Students should see the academic catalog for their term of entry to determine their minimum required GPA.\

> **The Academic Catalog** lists the current GPA requirements by program. Students admitted in an earlier term may have a different requirement. See the Academic Catalog for your term of entry.

GPA Computation

The graduate GPA includes all hours and grades for all courses taken while enrolled as a graduate student. The GPA component of academic status is calculated at the end of each semester. At the point of calculation, graduate students must have a cumulative graduate GPA at or above their program's minimum and must have a semester GPA of at least 2.25 to be in good standing.

Academic Forgiveness

Students who are applying for re-entry to the Graduate College and who are returning after at least two years with a GPA significantly below their department minimum may petition the Graduate College for Academic Forgiveness. If granted, the student's GPA for graduation will be calculated based on previously taken coursework as identified in the re-entry process and the courses taken upon return. All courses will remain on the student's transcript.

> See Chapter 3.1 Grades and Grading System for information about repeated courses and for more information about grade points used in computations

Academic Standing

The Graduate College monitors minimum program cumulative and semester GPA and time limits for certain degree requirements, and failure to meet these requirements in any term can result in the student being not in

good academic standing or dropped from the Graduate College. Other factors that determine satisfactory academic progress are monitored by the student's program, and failure to meet these requirements can result in the program recommending to the Graduate College that the student be not in good academic standing or dropped from the Graduate College. All graduate students must meet the minimum program GPA specified by their program in order to have the degree certified and to graduate.

Good Academic Standing

Good academic standing requires more than an acceptable cumulative and semester GPA. Graduate students must make satisfactory progress in all aspects of their program in order to continue as students and to graduate. Good academic standing can also be referred to as full graduate standing, which is the normal status of graduate students with no holds (Chapter 2.3 Registration Deadlines and Holds) or limited status (Chapter 1.4 Admission Status) or academic warning status at the university.

Academic Warning (Not in Good Academic Standing)

Academic warning due to GPA. Students who are not in good academic standing due to GPA have one semester to improve their standing to good academic standing, or they will be dropped from the Graduate College. A student who has a cumulative graduate GPA below the degree program's minimum and/or a semester GPA below 2.25 at the end of any semester of enrollment will be placed on academic warning status. A student who has no cumulative graduate GPA recorded at the end of a fall or spring semester will be placed on academic warning status. Once a student has been placed on academic warning, the student must raise the cumulative GPA to their program's minimum by the end of the next semester of enrollment and must earn a semester GPA of at least 2.25 in the next semester of enrollment, or be dropped from the Graduate College.

Academic warning due to exceeded time limit. Students who have exceeded the time limit to complete their master's degree or doctoral degree must successfully petition the Graduate College to continue in their academic program. A student will be placed on Academic warning after one calendar year has passed from their initial time-to-degree limit.

Students who are not in good academic standing (academic warning) due to having exceeded the time limit to complete Stage II of their doctoral degree will have a fall or spring semester to improve their standing to good standing or will be dropped from the Graduate College.

Once a student is not in good academic standing due to an exceeded time limit, the student must complete that degree stage by the end of the warning period or be dropped from the Graduate College.

Academic warning based on program recommendation. Programs monitor the academic progress of their students. Factors that a program may use to assess academic progress include, but are not limited to, performance in course work; satisfactory and timely completion of all milestones as determined by the program;

satisfactory progress in research; overall graduate and/or program GPA; and performance on qualifying, preliminary, and other examinations. Failure to meet these requirements can result in the program recommending to the Graduate College that the student be not in good academic standing or dropped by the Graduate College. The Graduate College will review the recommendation. If it is determined that the student will be placed on academic warning status, the Graduate College will communicate the length of the warning period and requirements for returning to good academic standing.

Admission on limited status due to low GPA or no comparable bachelor's degree. Students who are admitted to the Graduate College on limited status because of no comparable bachelor's degree or low GPA are admitted on academic warning status (see Chapter 1.4 Admission Status for more information). If these students do not meet the minimum GPA for their program in the first fall or spring semester of graduate work, they will receive a notice of drop status from the Graduate College.

Drop Status

A graduate student placed on academic warning status who fails to improve their academic standing by the end of the warning period will receive a notice of drop status from the Graduate College. This action prohibits the student from registering and drops any courses for which the student has pre-registered. The student may request reinstatement to the Graduate College through the petition process. The Graduate

College will consider petitions containing strong support from the academic program they wish to pursue and strong justification based on other factors pertinent to the program's determination of satisfactory academic progress.

GPA for Graduation

All graduate students must meet the minimum degree GPA specified by the degree program in order to have their degree certified and to graduate.

3.3 Transfer of Credit

There are two types of credit that a graduate student may wish to transfer:

1. credit completed outside the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, or
2. University of Illinois Urbana Champaign graduate level credit.

Different rules apply for each type of transfer of credit.

Transferring Credit from Another Institution

Graduate students may request to transfer credit earned from another institution to be counted toward a graduate degree. This is generally limited to a maximum of 12 semester hours. Credit that can be transferred must be graduate level credit that meets the following additional criteria:

- that has not previously been applied toward a degree or other transcripted credential,
- that is graded graduate-level credit from an accredited institution, and
- for which the student has achieved a grade of B or better, or received a Satisfactory grade in the case of a Satisfactory/Unsatisfactory grading mode.

When supporting requests for transfer credit, it is the program's responsibility to determine whether the credit is still relevant to the current degree.

Students utilizing transfer credit from another institution to count toward their degree need to be aware of residency requirements and how those limits effect the total number of hours applied. Factors to consider include:

1. Credit from outside the Graduate College may not be transferred to count toward Stage II or Stage III of a doctoral program (See Chapter 6.2 Time Limits for Doctoral Degrees).
2. To request transfer of credit from outside the Graduate College, a student should submit the appropriate form, accompanied by official transcripts, and validation by subject matter experts in the student's department that the credit is both applicable and of an appropriate level of difficulty.
3. Most transfer credit from outside the university will be reflected on the transcript without course titles and grades. The exceptions are:
    - Graduate credit transferred from the University of Illinois at Chicago or from the University of Illinois at Springfield.
    - Graduate credit earned through the BTAA Traveling Scholar Program.

Transferring Credit between Programs within the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Graduate students may request transfer of credit within the university to be counted toward a graduate degree. For these requests, there is no limit on the number of hours that a student may request be transferred.

Graduate students may request transfer of credit from one program at this university to another program at this university as long as it was not applied toward another degree and both departments involved approve the transfer of credit from one program to the other. Credit that can be transferred within the university includes:

- Credit taken while enrolled as a Illinois undergraduate student
- Credit taken while enrolled as a Illinois non-degree student
- Credit earned while enrolled in different graduate program
- Credit earned through the BTAA Traveling Scholar Program.

To request a transfer of credit, a student should submit the appropriate form. The Graduate College requires that the transfer of such work into a graduate program be approved by the program's department or governing unit.

Chapter 4
Graduate Degree and Graduation Requirements

Students are bound by the program and degree requirements in effect at their term of admission and are expected to be aware of these requirements. Students are not obligated to follow any subsequent changes to degree requirements unless the student has been Absent without Leave from the program (see Leave of Absence policy for details). Additional specific information on master's and post master's degree requirements (Chapter 5 Requirements for Master's Degrees, Certificates of Advanced Study, Artist's Diplomas, and Graduate Certificates), and doctoral degree requirements (Chapter 6 Requirements for Doctoral Degrees) can be found in this handbook.

4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements

Program Requirements

Requirements for specific graduate degrees are listed in the appropriate sections of the Academic Catalog and in departmental handbooks. All departments should distribute a handbook or statement to their graduate students listing the requirements for the graduate degree programs to which they are admitted.

Registration Requirements

In order to receive a graduate degree, a student must be admitted to the degree program and enrolled in the program for at least one term after admission, which could be spring, summer, or fall. To be counted toward the graduate degree, hours must be at the 400-level or greater and approved for graduate credit.

Curriculum Changes

Students who wish to change their degree program must request a curriculum change.

Students who are completing or abandoning their current degree program and wish to join a new graduate program must apply for a curriculum change and be approved for admission by the new program and the Graduate College.

Students who wish to concurrently pursue multiple degrees within their graduate department may request to add a secondary curriculum to their student record. This includes doctoral students requesting to be awarded a master's degree while pursuing their doctoral degree program. This may also include students requesting to be awarded a certificate while pursuing their primary degree program.

Students who wish to concurrently pursue multiple degrees from multiple departments must obtain approval from both departments as both programs will remain active within their curriculum record.

Some programs may allow students to apply for a curriculum change using the petition process, while other programs may require a full graduate application with all required materials, including an application fee. Students should contact their newly proposed program of study for instructions. However, all secondary curriculum requests should be submitted using the petition process.

Students should note that tuition assessment and tuition and fee benefits are tied to the program in which they are enrolled. An approved change in curriculum during the term that occurs after tuition has been assessed and payments credited may result in recalculation of tuition assessments that result in the student incurring additional expenses. Students on fellowships should consult their program regarding potential impacts on their eligibility to continue to hold their fellowship if approved for a curriculum change.

International students with F-1 or J-1 visas who change curriculum from one program to another are required to obtain new immigration documents from International Student and Scholar Services.

Residence Credit

A certain amount of credit hours for each degree received from this campus must be taken as residence credit. Residence credit includes:

- graduate credit earned through an on-campus course at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign,
- graduate credit earned through an Urbana-Champaign off-campus course or program,
- graduate credit transferred from the University of Illinois at Chicago or from the University of Illinois at Springfield,
- graduate credit earned through the BTAA Traveling Scholar Program, and
- credit earned in the College of Medicine that is approved for application to the student's graduate program for students in the Medical Scholars Program.

Students should also be aware of the transfer policies related to this type of credit used toward a degree.

> Residence requirements are outlined in Rule 3-801 of the Student Code and in this handbook as related to specific degrees.

Proficiency Examinations

Departments may allow students to satisfy specific requirements through proficiency examinations; however, in such cases, credit cannot apply toward the required hours for the graduate degree. Students should check with their department for additional information.

Research Credit and 599

A student cannot deposit a thesis without record of registration in thesis research credit (599). Graduate students should register for research credit during semesters when they are working on the thesis.

Departments may set criteria that determine at what point in the program students may begin registering for 599 credits. Registration in 599 must always be done with the approval of the student's adviser.

Faculty will assign a "S" or "U" grade at the end of each semester to indicate satisfactory or unsatisfactory progress. S/U grades do not impact GPA, but if there is a history of unsatisfactory progress on thesis research, the student may be placed on academic warning status through the department recommended academic warning process.

Students who have registered for thesis research credit and who later decide to complete the non-thesis option of the degree may graduate with graded 599 credit. It may be appropriate to convert some of the thesis research credit into project hours. It will be up to the department to determine if any of the thesis research credit may apply towards non-thesis degree requirements.

Second Degree in a Similar Area

An individual should not receive another degree for work that is substantially similar to the work used to complete a previous degree. Therefore, the Graduate College will generally not allow the awarding of a second graduate degree in an area in which a graduate degree at an equivalent level (master's or doctoral) has already been earned. This rule applies to cases where the previous degree is from this university or from another institution. Requests for exceptions may be allowed in cases where it is clear that the student's degree programs differ significantly. These decisions are made during the process of admission to the Graduate College or when a change of curriculum is requested.

Graduate Majors

A graduate major is an official program of study designation for the academic record.

Graduate Minors

A graduate minor is an approved program in a secondary area of study that relates to but is outside of a student's chosen major and may be included on an academic transcript. Students majoring in an area of study may not

pursue a minor in the same area.

Each program has its own procedures for applying to and completing the minor, and students should contact the department in which the minor is housed for details. Students who wish to add or drop a graduate minor from their academic record must submit the appropriate form to make the change to their academic program. An academic program change alters the requirements needed for graduation. Therefore, such changes should be made carefully and in consultation with the graduate program. It is at the discretion of the major degree department to determine which, if any, of the courses used to fulfill the minor will also be used to fulfill the requirements for the graduate major degree.

Minors will not be added retroactively to a student record after the major degree is conferred. Even though a minor may be included in a student's academic record, it will not show on a transcript until the degree has been conferred. A student's approved enrollment period will not be extended for the purpose of completing a minor.

If a student has requested to receive a minor and then wishes to change to a new program before receiving a degree, the new program must note through the Graduate College petition process if any of the courses used to fulfill the minor will also be used to fulfill the new major graduate degree requirements.

The Academic Catalog

Students should consult the Academic Catalog for a list of the graduate approved credentials, including majors, minors, concentrations, and certificates. A list of the approved joint degree programs and individual program requirements can also be found in the Academic Catalog, including any exceptions to the simultaneous conferral rule. For students interested in joint Bachelor's/Master's programs, the undergraduate college's Program of Study will have details about a specific program.

Graduate Concentrations

A graduate concentration constitutes a coherent program of study which gives a student more breadth or depth in their major. Approved concentrations are included on academic transcripts. Major-based concentrations are only open to a student majoring in the offering department. Floating concentrations are open to students in a select group of majors. A few majors require a concentration. Prior to pursuing a graduate concentration, it is important for students to verify that the graduate concentration they wish to pursue is available to their major degree program.

Because a concentration is intended to be within the major area of study, the hours required to fulfill the concentration should likewise apply toward completion of the degree. That is not to say, however, that completion

of a concentration within a degree couldn't require more hours than the degree itself, in that the student is earning an additional credential.

Students who wish to add or drop a graduate concentration from their academic record must submit a petition to request the change to their academic program. A change in concentration is a program change and will alter the requirements needed for graduation. Therefore, such changes should be made carefully and in consultation with the graduate program. Approvals are required from both the major department and the unit overseeing the concentration.

Concentrations will not be added retroactively to a student record after the major degree is conferred. A student's approved enrollment period will not be extended for the purpose of completing a concentration.

If a student is enrolled in a concentration and then wishes to change to a new program before receiving the degree, the new program must note on the request whether it will accept the concentration in its degree program and note which of the courses used to fulfill the concentration will also be used to fulfill the new major graduate degree. If the new program does not accept the concentration or the new program does not offer the concentration, the concentration will be removed from the student's record when the request to change program is processed.

Joint Degree Programs

A joint degree program is a campus-approved program in which a student concurrently pursues two specifically identified degrees that are conferred simultaneously. For graduate students, this is a combination of a graduate degree with one of the following: another graduate degree, an undergraduate degree, or a professional degree. The total time for the two degrees can be decreased by a predetermined maximum through the acceptance of required courses in one program as electives in the other, if so approved.

A student interested in pursuing joint degrees should consult both departments. A student in a joint degree program must be admitted to each degree program and be enrolled in each program for at least one term after admission, which could be spring, summer, or fall (see Chapter 4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements for information about changing programs), and must complete the minimum requirements for each degree. Doctoral students pursuing joint degrees may be enrolled in either program when they take their preliminary exams or defend their dissertation.

Joint bachelor's /master's programs. Approved joint programs include programs that combine a bachelor's and a master's degree in the same field. Like other joint degree programs, both the bachelor's and the master's degrees are generally awarded at the end of the program. Because of this, these students are admitted to the Graduate College before they have earned a bachelor's degree.

Dual Degree Programs

A dual degree program is defined as one in which a student pursues two post-baccalaureate degrees simultaneously. In dual degree programs, students must complete all requirements for each degree, without overlap. With the approval of both departments, students would have the opportunity to integrate their studies rather than completing the degrees in series. A student pursuing two post-baccalaureate degrees simultaneously must be admitted into each degree program and enrolled in each program for at least one term after admission (see Chapter 4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements for information about changing programs), in order to obtain both degrees. Dual degree students earning a doctoral degree may be enrolled in either program when they defend their dissertation.

Annual Academic Progress Reviews

Graduate units must conduct annual academic progress reviews for all graduate students enrolled in degree-seeking programs at least once every academic year. A written copy of the review must be given to the student and be placed in the student's academic file.

Ideally, academic progress reviews should include the following elements:

- a student self-report and assessment of academic progress,
- a review prepared by the adviser and at least one other faculty member to focus on an assessment of degree progress and student strengths and weaknesses. A copy of this written review is given to the student, and
- an opportunity for the student to discuss this review in person.

4.2 Graduation Requirements

Degree Conferral and Applying for Graduation

Graduate degrees are conferred in May, August, and December.

In order to receive a degree, a student must apply to be on the degree list for the intended graduation date using the Self-Service system. Deadlines for applying for graduation are noted on the Graduate College Academic Calendar. Applying for graduation is not the same as applying to participate in departmental or campus commencement ceremonies.

Academic record. A student may not receive a degree with a grade of I, NR, or DFR in any course on their graduate record, except in cases where the DFR grade has been successfully petitioned to remain.

Theses and Dissertations

A thesis or dissertation is an original, significant contribution to the scholarly literature of an academic discipline.

In this section, “thesis” refers to both master’s theses and doctoral dissertations.

All graduate students whose programs require the completion of a thesis must deposit their manuscript electronically in the Graduate College.

Faculty and departmental approval. The student's adviser (for master’s students) or final exam committee (for doctoral students) as well as the department head (or authorized signatory) must recommend that the thesis be accepted for deposit before it can be deposited with the Graduate College. In the case of a doctoral student who passed the final exam with one dissenting vote, the dissenting member may, but is not required to, recommend the thesis for deposit.

Format. Only theses that meet the formatting and accessibility requirements set forth by the Graduate College will be accepted.

Deposit. The Graduate College does not require students to be registered at the time of deposit, but some departments may, so students should consult with their department before depositing. A thesis will not be accepted for deposit until all required materials have been submitted and all corrections requested by the Graduate College Thesis Office have been made. Deposit must be completed by the appropriate master’s or doctoral deposit deadlines set for each term. Upon deposit, the thesis becomes part of the student’s academic record. No changes may be made to a thesis after it has been deposited by the Graduate College.

Dissemination. Theses that are deposited as a requirement for the awarding of a degree are considered to be publications. Copyrightable works prepared by students as part of the requirements for a university degree program are deemed to be the property of the student.

As a condition of degree award, the university has the royalty-free right to retain, use, and distribute a limited number of copies of the thesis, together with the right to require its publication for archival use (see Article III Section 4, University of Illinois Board of Trustees’ General Rules).

In order to best disseminate and archive the significant work of University of Illinois graduates, the Graduate College requires that every thesis and the abstract be published. The Graduate College will determine the method of publication that most effectively secures the existence of the thesis in perpetuity. The theses will be available to the public through the University Library.

Permissions for previously published work included in the thesis. Prior publication of parts of the thesis is increasingly common. If the copyright to the published work has been transferred to the publisher (or to any other party), the student should secure written permission from the current owner of the copyright to include the previously published material in the thesis to be submitted for deposit. Copies of these copyright permissions should be included with the student's deposit materials.

Patent review. If a student's thesis contains potentially patentable information, a student may wish to have the thesis held by the Graduate College Thesis Office while patentability is assessed. Holding a thesis does not postpone degree conferral or graduation. A student wishing to have a thesis held during the patent review process must contact the Office of Technology Management (OTM) prior to deposit. OTM will review the student's request and notify the Graduate College if a thesis is to be held.

Request for Degree Certification Letter

A student who has fulfilled all of the degree requirements before the next conferral date may need certification for employment or to meet visa requirements. To request a degree certification letter, the student should use the Degree Certification Letter Request form, found on the Graduate College website. A student who has not deposited their thesis with the Graduate College (when deposit is required) or who is enrolled in any course other than research credit is not eligible to receive a degree certification letter.

Commencement

Commencement is a celebratory event, not a degree requirement. For details about participation, see the Commencement Office website.

Chapter 5
Requirements for Master's Degrees, Certificates of Advanced Study, Artist's Diplomas, and Graduate Certificates

This chapter includes the overarching campus-level requirements for Master's Degrees, Certificates of Advanced Study, Artist's Diplomas, and Graduate Certificates.

5.1 Master's Degrees

Credit Hour Requirements

The Graduate College requires a minimum of 32 semester hours of graduate credit for the master's degree, although a number of programs require more. At least 12 hours must be at the 500-level or greater and approved for graduate credit (including thesis, research, or independent study credit), and 8 of these 12 hours must be in the major. Half or more of the hours applied toward a master's degree must be earned in courses counted for residence credit.

Examinations

The Graduate College does not require a final examination or thesis committee for the master's degree. Departments that have such requirements determine their own rules for committee membership and administration of the examination. The Graduate College does not require master's students to be registered during the term in which they take their final exam, but some departments may.

Completion of Theses

When a thesis is required for the master's degree, it must be deposited with the Graduate College. The Graduate College requires that master's theses be approved by a member of the Graduate Faculty. In programs requiring a thesis deposit, the Graduate College does not require master's students to be registered during the term in which they deposit, but some departments may.

Time Limits

A master's degree student is expected to complete all degree requirements within five years of first registering as a degree-seeking student in the master's degree program, unless the student is enrolled in a program with a different time limit that has been approved by the Graduate College. Students who have not completed the

degree by this time will be put on academic warning status. When supporting petitions for extensions of time to degree, it is the program's responsibility to determine whether old course work is still relevant to the current degree.

5.2 Certificates of Advanced Study

Some departments offer a Certificate of Advanced Study for students who are interested in additional professional training beyond the master's degree but are not planning to obtain the doctoral degree. A master's degree is required for admission to these degree programs.

Credit Hour Requirements

These programs require completion of at least 32 semester hours of coursework beyond the master's degree. However, requirements do vary, and information concerning specific advanced certificate programs is available from departmental offices and in the appropriate Academic Catalog.

Time Limits

A student pursuing a Certificate of Advanced Study is expected to complete all degree requirements within five years of first registering as a degree-seeking student in the degree program, unless the student is enrolled in a program with a different time limit that has been approved by the Graduate College. Students who have not completed the degree by this time will be put on academic warning status. When supporting petitions for extensions of time to degree, it is the program's responsibility to determine whether old course work is still relevant to the current degree.

5.3 Artist's Diplomas

The School of Music offers an Artist's Diploma degree, which is intended only for musicians at the highest level of artistic accomplishment and potential. Upon completion of the Artist's Diploma, students are expected to be ready for entrance into the music profession as a solo artist, member of an orchestra or chamber or jazz ensemble, or as an apprentice in an opera company.

Credit Hour Requirements

This degree requires completion of 32 semester hours of course work beyond the master's degree.

Time Limits

A student pursuing an Artist's Diploma is expected to complete all degree requirements within five years of first registering as a degree-seeking student in the degree program, unless the student is enrolled in a program with a different time limit that has been approved by the Graduate College. Students who have not completed the degree by this time will be put on academic warning status. When supporting petitions for extensions of time to degree, it is the program's responsibility to determine whether old course work is still relevant to the current degree.

5.4 Graduate Certificates

The Graduate Certificate is earned through successful completion of a pre-defined program of graduate-level courses. The program must encompass at least ten weeks of instruction and a total of at least twelve credit hours of graduate-level courses. All courses required by a Graduate Certificate must be at the graduate level, listed at the 400-level or higher. A minimum cumulative GPA of 2.75 is required for awarding of the Graduate Certificate.

No transfer credit from another institution may be used to satisfy the requirements for a Graduate Certificate.

Credit Hour Requirements

Credit hours earned toward a Graduate Certificate may be used, in part or in whole, toward no more than one graduate degree program, at the discretion of the graduate degree program. Admission into a Graduate Certificate program does not imply admission into a graduate degree program. Students completing a Graduate Certificate must apply to and be admitted into a graduate degree program before any credit hours earned through the Graduate Certificate can contribute toward a graduate degree. Per standard policy, completion of a graduate degree program requires enrollment for a minimum of one semester in the graduate degree program as a degree-seeking student.

Time Limits

The Graduate Certificate program must be completed within two years of admission to ensure that the course work is current and relevant to the learning outcomes of the program.

Graduate Certificates are awarded at the end of each traditional semester (fall, spring, summer) following the campus graduate degree conferral schedule. Students are issued a Certificate Diploma by the Office of the Registrar as well as receiving a credential notation on their transcripts.

See Chapter 15 Graduate Certificates for more information about Graduate Certificates.

Chapter 6
Requirements for Doctoral Degrees

This chapter includes the overarching campus-level requirements for Doctoral Degrees.

6.1 Credit Hour Requirements

Doctoral degrees require successful completion of a minimum of 96 semester hours of graduate credit (see below for doctoral degree stages), except for those programs approved otherwise.

Doctoral degree students, regardless of transfer credits or a master's degree completed elsewhere, must complete at least 64 hours of residence credit (Chapter 4.1 Graduate Degree Requirements) out of the total of 96 hours required for the doctoral degree, and should also see Chapter 3.3 Transfer of Credit for information about transfer credit. Thesis hours count toward residence credit.

6.2 Time Limits for Doctoral Degrees

A doctoral student entering in Stage I is required to graduate within seven years of first registering as a degree-seeking student in a graduate program. A student who enters the graduate program with an approved previous master's degree that would satisfy Stage I of the doctoral program is considered entering at Stage II and is required to graduate within six years of first registering as a degree-seeking student in a graduate program. Students who begin in a master's program and then enter a doctoral program would be required to graduate within eight years of first registration in the Graduate College. Stages of a doctoral program are described below. Time extensions can be made under extenuating circumstance, as described below.

Expected Graduation Date Calculation

- Admitted to doctoral program as Stage I (no approved master's): seven years
- Admitted to doctoral program as Stage II (with approved master's): six years
- Admitted to University of Illinois master's program and continuation into doctoral program (where master's program fulfills Stage I of doctoral program): eight years from admission to master's program

Doctoral Stages and Time Limits

Stage I. A student is considered to be in Stage I from initial enrollment in the graduate program to completion of a master's degree or its equivalent. Each department should have a procedure for evaluating a student's progress at this first stage of doctoral work. Elements of this evaluation will include GPA, along with other factors related to good academic standing and satisfactory progress. In some departments, this evaluation may take the form of a qualifying examination or other examination or series of examinations, which a student must pass before entering Stage II of the doctoral degree program. Evaluation of progress in Stage I, whether by examination or other formal review, should take place no later than the end of the second year after a student enters the doctoral program. The evaluation results should be communicated in writing to the student. Students who apply to a doctoral program having already completed a master's degree equivalent to that awarded by the University of Illinois are generally considered to have completed Stage I of the program unless the department deems otherwise, in which case the department must notify the student of the stage in which they are entering the program.

Stage II. A doctoral student is considered to be in Stage II from completion of the master's degree or equivalent to completion of all departmental requirements (except the defense and deposit of the dissertation), including passing the preliminary examination. In some programs, doctoral students entering with a master's degree will take a qualifying examination early in Stage II. Stage II usually consists of one or more years devoted to course work and research in preparation for the preliminary examination. Stage II ends with the successful passing of the preliminary examination. Students who have not successfully passed their preliminary examination by the deadline (as determined by their admission stage) of their graduate program will be not in good academic standing. See table below for deadlines based on admission stage. The deadline to complete Stage II is two years less than the expected graduation date/deadline to complete Stage III.

Stage III. Stage III is the time from the completion of Stage II to graduation. Stage III consists of the student conducting research and writing their dissertation, successful passing of their final examination (defense), and deposit of their dissertation. Students in Stage III must have a director of research (who is often the student's adviser) who oversees the dissertation research (See Chapter 6.4 Directors of Research). Stage III must be completed by the deadlines in the table below based on admission stage. Students who have not completed Stage III by this time can receive one time extension before being placed on academic warning.

Deadlines to Complete Degree Stages Based on Admission Stage

Admission Stage	Stage I	Stage II	Stage III
Admitted to doctoral program as Stage I (no approved master's)	Approximately 2 years (not monitored by the Graduate College	End of year 5	End of year 7
Admitted to doctoral program as Stage II (with approved master's)	Not applicable (completed prior to enrolling)	End of year 4	End of year 6

Admission Stage	Stage I	Stage II	Stage III
Admitted to University of Illinois master's program and continue into doctoral program	Completion of Illinois master's program (typically 2 years)	End of year 6 (since first enrollment in master's program)	End of year 8 (since first enrollment in master's program)

Leaves and Changing Programs

- Degree time limits are not automatically extended for students who change curriculum from one doctoral program to another doctoral program within the Graduate College.
- Degree time limits are not automatically extended for students who do not register and who are not on an approved leave of absence.
- The process to request extensions is described below.

Re-Entering

In some unusual scenarios after review by the student's department and Graduate College, it may be appropriate to restart the time limit for an individual student. Factors that would be considered include the amount of time spent in the previous program and the amount of time away from the program. In cases where the time limit is restarted, the student would follow the degree requirements for the new term of admission. This is documented through the re-entry process.

Time Extensions

Exceptions to the above time limits are reviewed on a case-by-case basis through the Graduate College petition process.

Use of Old Coursework

When supporting petitions for extensions of time to degree, it is the program's responsibility to determine whether old course work is still relevant to the current degree.

Exceptions to degree time limits. There are a few programs that have exceptions to the time to degree limits.

- For all College of Education doctoral programs, the time to degree limit is seven years from first enrollment in a doctoral program, after completing the master's degree (effective Fall 2000).
- For doctoral students in Anthropology, the time limit is ten years from the enrollment in a doctoral program if no master's degree was earned previously (effective Fall 1999).

Second Preliminary Examination

If more than five years elapse between a doctoral student's preliminary and final examinations, the student is required to demonstrate that their broad knowledge of the field is current by passing a second preliminary examination. It is not adequate that the student has sufficient current knowledge in the area of the dissertation. The form of the second preliminary examination need not be identical to that of the first. Scholarly publications and college-level teaching assignments may be used as partial evidence of the student's current knowledge of their field, but a preliminary examination committee must be appointed by the Graduate College, an examination given, and its result reported to the Graduate College.

Dissertation Deposit

Students are expected to deposit their dissertation promptly following their final exam to preserve the currency of the research and the integrity of the document approved by the committee. Students must deposit their dissertation within three semesters (including the current semester). The deposit must be made by the published deadline for that semester. After this time, a new final examination may need to be conducted.

6.3 Registration Requirements for Doctoral Degrees

Registration for Doctoral Exams

The Graduate College requires that all doctoral students be registered for the entire academic term during which they take the preliminary examination and the term during which they take the final examination, regardless of when the dissertation will be deposited or when the degree will be conferred. For this purpose only, "academic term" is defined as extending to and including the day before the first day of the following academic term. If enough thesis credits have been accumulated, registration for 0 hours is acceptable.

Registration for Dissertation Deposit

The Graduate College does not require that students be registered for the semester that they deposit their thesis; however, individual departments may have other registration requirements, so students should check with their department for details.

> See Chapter 2.4 Registration Options for more information about enrollment in GC 599 for loan deferral. For students in approved joint degree programs and in the Medical Scholars Program, registration in either program during the academic term in which they defend meets the enrollment requirement.

6.4 Directors of Research

The research nature of doctoral degrees requires a student to work closely with a director(s) of research who oversees the graduate student's research project and dissertation. A director of research is often the student's adviser and is normally a member of the Graduate Faculty. It is the student's responsibility to find a faculty member who agrees to serve as their director of research. Students are encouraged to establish this relationship early, and departments may have expectations about when this occurs. Doctoral students in Stage III must have a director of research in order to be in good standing.

6.5 Doctoral Committees and Examinations

Committees are formed and examinations given at various stages of graduate study in order to monitor and ensure the quality of graduate work. This chart provides an overview of committee requirements. For complete information, see the relevant sections below.

Exam Type	Graduate College Appointment & Approval Required	Registration Required**
Qualifying Examination Committee*	not required by the Graduate College	Preliminary Examination Committee
Yes	Yes	Dissertation Committee
not required by the Graduate College	Final Examination (Defense) Committee	Yes
Yes		

* *Committee nomenclature may vary by department; for example, the qualifying exam is sometimes called a comprehensive exam*

** *See the Registration Requirements section of this handbook*

Qualifying Examination and Qualifying Examination Committee

The Graduate College does not require qualifying examinations, but departments may. Qualifying exams, usually given at the end of Stage I of the doctoral work, evaluate the student's knowledge in the field and preparation for

the doctoral program. The format of these examinations may be written, oral, or both, as determined by the program. The program must clearly communicate information about the format and rules (i.e., closed-book) to all students in advance. Departments may internally appoint committees to conduct these examinations.

Dissertation Committee

The dissertation committee does not need to be formally appointed or approved. The purpose of this committee is to advise the student with dissertation research and effectively monitor the student's progress, often before the student is ready to form the final examination committee. The Graduate College encourages formation of a dissertation committee as early as possible after the successful completion of the preliminary examination. In units with preliminary examinations that include the presentation of a proposal for the doctoral research, the dissertation committee membership may be substantially the same as the preliminary examination committee. The dissertation committee membership may also be the same or essentially the same as the final examination committee. There is no time limit on the duration of service of the dissertation committee, other than the length of time that the student is allowed to complete the degree.

Preliminary and Final Examination Committees

The Graduate College requires preliminary and final examinations for all doctoral degrees, and the Dean of the Graduate College appoints doctoral committees in accordance with the membership requirements.

Registration. Students must be enrolled for the entire academic term in which the preliminary exam occurs. See Chapter 6.3 Registration Requirements for Doctoral Degrees for details.

Committee appointment process. The preliminary examination is conducted by a committee appointed by the Dean of the Graduate College upon recommendation of the executive officer of the unit. Persons authorized by the department to submit committee requests (as assigned in the Graduate College Roles & Access Manager) may make requests on behalf of the executive officer. The committee must be appointed before the exam takes place, and the Graduate College strongly recommends submission of the Request for Appointment of Doctoral Examination Committee form at least three weeks in advance of the exam date.

Once a committee has been appointed it remains active for 90 days or until a pass or fail result is submitted to the Graduate College, except in the case of a Defer result, see below. Any revisions to the membership of an active committee must be approved by the Graduate College in advance of the examination.

If the examination did not take place within 90 calendar days after the date on which the Graduate College appointed the committee, the committee is dissolved and a new committee must be appointed before the examination occurs. The newly appointed committee may, but is not required to, consist of the same members as the dissolved committee.

Membership Requirements

- Committees must include at least four voting members, at least three of whom must be members of the Graduate Faculty, and at least two of whom must also be tenured at the Urbana-Champaign campus.
- The chair must be a member of the Graduate Faculty. At the department's discretion, a co-chair may be appointed. If appointed, a co-chair must meet all the requirements that apply to the chair.
- If there are more than four voting members on the committee, at least half of the voting members must be members of the Graduate Faculty.
- The tenure requirement can be met by term members of the Graduate Faculty who retired or resigned with tenure for a period following their resignation or retirement, according to the Policy on Graduate Faculty Membership (Chapter 10 Graduate Faculty Membership).
- Upon departmental request, the Dean of the Graduate College may also appoint non-voting members to doctoral committees. Non-voting members do not need to be present at the examination. Non-voting members may be appointed but are rare on preliminary examination committees.

Exam Type	Minimum Voting Members Required	Minimum Graduate Faculty Members Required	Minimum Tenured Illinois Faculty Members Required
Preliminary Examination Committee	4	3 (Chair must be in Graduate Faculty)	2
Final Examination (Defense) Committee	4	3 (Chair must be in Graduate Faculty)	2

Remote participation. Synchronous remote participation of the student or committee member(s) is permitted on preliminary and final examination committees under the following conditions:

- Technology must allow all participants to communicate throughout the examination and to access all materials presented. Video technology is encouraged for remote committee members and required for a student participating remotely.
- The chair (or co-chair) is responsible for coordinating the use of any technology, for recessing the examination if technical problems prevent full participation, and for making arrangements to resume the examination promptly.

Role of the committee chair. Each committee must have a chair. The committee chair is responsible for convening the committee, conducting the examination, ensuring all members can participate fully, communicating any required revisions to the student, and submitting the appropriate forms to the department in which the student is enrolled for submission to the Graduate College. For final exams, the committee chair may designate another voting member of the committee to communicate the required revisions.

Inclusion of non-Graduate Faculty members. Departments may request the inclusion of non-Graduate Faculty members who make a significant contribution as voting members of the committee; these individuals must be approved in advance by the Dean of the Graduate College. To request the approval of a non-Graduate Faculty member to serve as a voting member, a curriculum vitae for the individual and a justification from the chair of the committee must accompany the doctoral committee appointment request. Non-Graduate Faculty voting members, must have earned a terminal degree in their field of study and must have demonstrated expertise that qualifies them to judge the quality of the student's research and its contribution to the field. Each voting member must be well-positioned to vote independently and must be free from conflicts of interest. Additional guidance for nominating external members is available on the Graduate College website.

Format and Results of a Preliminary Examination

Format

- Preliminary examinations may be oral or written or both, depending on the unit's policy, and generally evaluate the student's overall and specific knowledge in the field. Preliminary examinations also usually include an oral presentation to review the feasibility and appropriateness of a student's dissertation research proposal.
- The doctoral degree program prescribes the scope, format, and procedures associated with the examination, including the composition of the committee. The program must clearly communicate information about the format and rules (e.g., closed-book) to all students in advance. The student must be promptly notified of the examination result.
- All voting members of the committee must participate in the oral examination, the deliberation, and determination of the results of the oral examination.
- No audio or video recording of the examination or deliberation may be made without the express permission of the student and all members of the committee.

Results

Decisions of the preliminary examination committee must be unanimous and are recorded on the Preliminary Exam Result form. The committee may make one of three decisions:

- **Pass the student.**
- **Fail the student.** A program may, but is not required to, grant the student another opportunity to take the examination after completing additional course work, independent study, or research, as recommended by the committee. However, if a second attempt is given, a new committee must be appointed by the Graduate College. The new committee may, but does not have to, consist of the same members as the original committee.

- **Defer the decision.** If this option is chosen:
    - the same committee must re-examine the student,
    - the second exam must occur within 180 calendar days of the date of first exam, and
    - the outcome of the second exam must be pass or fail.

After a fail result, a student will only be allowed to take the preliminary examination one additional time while working toward the completion of any one program of study.

Format and Results of a Final Examination (Defense)

Format

- The examination consists of an oral examination open to the academic community of the university followed by a private deliberation of the committee. The student is informed of the result immediately following the deliberation.
- All voting members of the committee must participate for the entire duration of the final examination the deliberation, and determination the of the result.
- Students must adhere to departmental procedures or requirements. These procedures and requirements must be clearly communicated to all students in advance of the exam.
- For final examination committees, the student's dissertation adviser (i.e., director of research) need not be the chair of the committee. Co-directors of research are acceptable.
- For final examination committees, committee members should be chosen for their expertise in the student's research area but may also be chosen to give diversity in viewpoint, methodology, or academic discipline. The faculty of a department may establish procedures or requirements for introducing diversity in the membership of the final examination committee (e.g., by including members from more than one sub-discipline within the department, from other departments, or from other institutions).
- No audio or video recording of the examination or deliberation may be made without the express permission of the student and all members of the committee.

Results

The decision of the final exam committee is recorded on the Final Exam Result form. The voting members of the committee must make one of two decisions:

- **Pass the student.** The student passes the final exam if the Director(s) of Research vote pass and no more than one of the remaining Committee members votes fail. The Committee will indicate on the Final Exam

Result form if revisions are required. The Committee will sign the Thesis/Dissertation Approval form following the examination and after the completion of any required revisions.

- **Fail the student.** The student fails the final exam if a Director of Research votes fail or if two or more Committee members vote fail. A program may, but is not required to, grant the student another opportunity to take the examination after completing additional research or writing, as recommended by the committee. However, a new committee must be appointed by the Graduate College. The new committee may, but does not have to, consist of the same members as the original committee.

After a fail result a student will only be allowed to take the final examination one additional time while working toward the completion of any one program of study.

Second preliminary exam. If more than five years elapse between a doctoral student's preliminary and final examinations, the student is required to demonstrate that their broad knowledge of the field is current by passing a second preliminary examination (see Chapter 6.2 Time Limits for Doctoral Degrees for details).

Preliminary and Final Exam Results

The results of the Preliminary Exam and the Final Exam should be communicated to the student and to the Graduate College as soon as possible after the conclusion of the exam regardless of the result. The Committee Chair is delegated to record the results of the exam and the votes of all committee members. Committee members will be included in the results notification provided by the Chair. The executive officer or authorized person must affirm the accuracy of the result. The result of the examination is communicated to the student and to the Graduate College as soon as possible after the conclusion of the exam. The result must be received by the Graduate College no later than 90 days after the appointment of the committee. Examination result decisions are maintained by the Graduate College.

6.6 Doctoral Exit Surveys

Doctoral students at the University of Illinois complete two exit surveys. All doctoral students are required to complete both the Doctoral Exit Survey and the Survey of Earned Doctorates and the at the time of the final thesis deposit. Students may decline to answer any or all of the questions.

The Doctoral Exit Survey allows the University of Illinois to compare students' experiences in its doctoral programs with those of students from peer institutions. Data from this survey helps improve doctoral programs on our campus. De-identified data from this survey are forwarded to the Association of American Universities (AAU) Data Exchange. Data compiled by AAU from member institutions facilitates the sharing of information nationally and provides a data pool that is used to shape graduate education at the national level.

The Survey of Earned Doctorates is conducted by the RTI International for the National Science Foundation, National Institutes of Health, and other supporting institutions. For more information about the Survey of Earned Doctorates, visit the website.

Chapter 7
Tuition and Fees

Tuition and fee assessments are based on the student's Illinois residency status, the college and curriculum of enrollment, and the amount of credit for which the student registers. The Office of the Registrar's website contains complete information about tuition and fees assessments, current fee structures, and which services are supported by specific fees.

In addition to tuition, certain courses carry a fee to cover instructional costs. These fees may apply to computer equipment and usage, laboratory equipment and supplies, musical instruments for practice, and similar instructional costs. Instructional fees are noted in the Class Schedule and assessed along with tuition and other fees.

Fee Assessments

Credit is organized by "ranges" for on-campus programs (e.g., Range I for fall and spring terms is 12 or more hours), and the amount of tuition and fee assessments may vary by range of enrollment. For example, if a student registers for fewer than 6 hours in fall or spring terms, or less than 3 hours in the summer term, certain fees would not be assessed. Without the fee assessment, the student would not have access to the services associated with that fee. Online programs are assessed tuition per credit hour. Please see the Office of the Registrar's website for current information about fees.

Billing

Once a month, the university e-mails students to remind them to view their student account for recent activity and to pay any amount due by the deadline. The student account is available online through Self-Service for students and authorized payers, and includes all student account transactions such as payments received and charges and credits for tuition, fees, and housing.

7.1 Adjustments, Cancellation, Withdrawal, and Refunds

A student's assessment of tuition and fees may be adjusted for a number of reasons, including changing the number of hours of registration, canceling registration, or withdrawing from the university. Because tuition and fee assessments are based on the hours of credit organized by "ranges," adding or dropping classes could result in a student moving from one range to another, which would result in either an increase or decrease in the assessment.

Cancellation of registration is only permitted if a student has not attended classes and has not used any university services. If a student wishes to cancel registration and avoid payment of the tuition and fee charges, the student must complete a Withdrawal/Cancellation form and submit it before 5:00 p.m. on the last business day before the first day of instruction of the term. This applies to forms submitted both electronically or through mail. A student must obtain permission from their departmental office and International Student and Scholar Services (for international students only) before submitting the Withdrawal/Cancellation form to the Graduate College. If the Graduate College approves the cancellation request, all tuition and fee charges are removed from the account for that term.

A student who wishes to drop all courses after the cancellation deadline must withdraw from the university for that term. This is applicable even if the student had been registered for only one course. Students withdrawing from the university are refunded on a prorated basis until a specified date in the semester after which no refund is available. No portion of the health insurance fee or health service fee is refundable. Students who have paid health insurance and health service fees will continue to be covered and are eligible to receive services for the corresponding coverage period for that term.

Special refund policies apply to students who withdraw to enter active duty in the armed forces or other approved national defense service. See the complete policy, Rule 3-313 of the Student Code.

If a student reduces course registration to a lower assessment range (e.g., from Range I to Range II), the student may be eligible for a refund. Refund policies vary depending on what action is taken and when the action is taken. Before the student may receive a refund, the university must first refund the appropriate financial aid programs providing assistance to the student. If the student is indebted to the university when they are due to receive a refund, the amount owed is deducted from the amount to be refunded.

Resources

- Contact the Bursar's Office for questions about your account.
- See the Office of the Registrar's website for details on withdrawal and refund.
- Review the university Refund Schedule (on the Office of the Registrar's website) for specific dates for refunds.

7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy

Tuition rates for graduate students are recommended by the Office of the Provost and approved by the Board of Trustees. Tuition remission rates that are charged to research grants are determined by the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research & Innovation. The full-time employee waiver policy is set by the Board of Trustees and administered by Illinois Human Resources. The Graduate College reviews changes to the assistantship tuition waiver levels that are requested by disciplinary colleges, as dictated by the Tuition Waiver Policy (discussed below).

Authority to waive tuition for graduate students with assistantships is vested in the Graduate College as a unit of the Office of the Provost. Below is an explanation of the campus tuition waiver policy for graduate students, including information specific to graduate assistantships, fellowships, and traineeships, and provisions that apply to all waiver-generating graduate appointments.

> **You can download** a Tuition Waiver Guide created by the Graduate College to assist units with the navigation of Graduate College tuition waiver policies.

Assistantships

Waiver-generating assistantship appointments are defined as appointments ranging from 25 percent through 67 percent time (based on a 40-hour week) for at least three-quarters of the academic term. The academic term is the period starting on the first day of classes and ending on the last day of final examinations. For fall and spring terms, three quarters is defined as 91 days. For summer term, it is defined as 41 days. A teaching assistant appointment between 25 percent and 67 percent for at least 21 days in Summer I (4-week part of summer term) will be considered a waiver-generating appointment.

The tuition waiver policy for graduate assistantships is established by the campus, with certain provisions tied to the graduate program in which the student is enrolled (as identified by the graduate program code). Before units can elect to make any changes to their tuition waiver policy, they must seek and receive approval from the Graduate College and the Office of the Provost. Students are governed by the waiver policy in effect at the time of first enrollment in the program as long as they are in good academic standing and are making sufficient progress toward graduation in that program.

The principal provisions of the policy specific to assistantship appointments include:

Tuition Waiver Designation Categories

- **Cost-recovery and self-supporting programs.** Students in approved cost-recovery and self-supporting programs are not eligible to receive tuition and fee waivers except statutory waivers. For example, these students may not hold waiver-generating appointments, receive stand-alone waivers, or receive employee waivers. However, students are eligible to receive tuition scholarships.
- **Traditional programs with full waivers.** Waiver-generating assistantship appointments provide waivers of all assessed tuition for students in certain curricula. Depending on the student's program and residency status, tuition assessment may include an in-state assessment, a non-resident assessment, and a program-specific tuition assessment.
- **Traditional programs with base-rate waivers.** In certain curricula, students with waiver-generating assistantships receive base-rate waivers. A base-rate waiver covers only the resident portion of the graduate base-rate tuition. The student is responsible for paying the remaining tuition, which may include a non-resident assessment and a program-specific assessment.
- Units may use their funds to pay any portion of the remaining tuition for assistants enrolled in base-rate waiver curricula. An appropriate source of funds must be used and appropriate account codes specified so the transactions can be properly tracked. Grant or contract funds may not be used for direct payments to students for tuition.
- The Graduate College maintains a table of tuition waiver designations for graduate programs within each college. This table will be published annually by January 31, for tuition waiver policies that will be in effect for the following fall semester. At the end of each fiscal year, the Graduate College will reconcile the previous year's reimbursement charges and communicate these to impacted units.

Reimbursement from research grants and contracts. Currently, a provisional rate of 64 percent of a graduate assistant's stipend is charged to research grants and contracts as tuition indirect cost on all projects that have the full, negotiated indirect cost rate. The tuition indirect cost funds do not get processed into the campus tuition fund and are instead processed as Institutional Cost Recovery (ICR) funds. Therefore, the amount of reimbursement that can be sought due to an assistantship tuition waiver is limited. The amount of the reimbursement is limited to the amount of tuition ICR collected by the appointing unit and appointing disciplinary college. No tuition indirect cost is currently charged to projects that have an approved indirect cost rate lower than the full, negotiated rate.

Reimbursement for assistants with multiple appointments. In the event of split appointments, please refer to the waiver priority policy below. In the event that the student has split appointments from two units outside of their academic college, units should agree in advance as to the responsibility for the value of the waiver (up to the established cap) for students that are in programs designated as reimbursable. Where there are no advance agreements, the default arrangement is for both of the appointing units to reimburse the academic college at the appropriate prorated basis. For example, if a student holds a 25 percent appointment in one unit and a 25

percent appointment in another unit, each unit would be responsible for reimbursement of half of the value of the tuition waiver (up to the established cap set by the reimbursement policy).

The Graduate College posts the Tuition Waiver Tables for each year online. You can also view the tables on the Graduate College website. Please note that these tables may be updated to include new programs during the year.

Reimbursement

Under the current budget policy, each disciplinary college receives the tuition income from graduate students enrolled in its programs; that income forms part of the college's operating budget. Therefore, an assistantship, through its associated tuition waiver, represents a reduction in potential income for the student's disciplinary college. Some degree programs are designated as reimbursable, which identifies programs that would be reimbursed from an appointing unit outside the college. Reimbursement will be required for the value of the waiver, with a cap set at 80 percent of resident graduate base-rate tuition per semester of appointment. Doctoral programs will not be designated as reimbursable programs.

Fellowships and Traineeships

A **fellowship** is defined as an award providing a stipend for living expenses at the established minimum or higher and demanding no services in return. Fellowship appointments are reviewed in the Graduate College, and the Graduate College decides whether an award is a fellowship.

Traineeships are research fellowships that are awarded to provide educational training in particular disciplinary areas and provide a stipend for living expenses.

The principle provisions of the policy specific to fellows and trainees include:

Cost-recovery or self-supporting programs. Students in approved cost-recovery or self-supporting programs are not eligible to receive fellowship or traineeship waivers. This means the student may receive an award that provides:

- stipend only, or
- both a stipend and full payment of tuition, or
- both a stipend and a tuition scholarship that covers some portion of tuition.

Tuition coverage. Eligible fellows and trainees receiving the established minimum or higher stipend (see the chart below) receive coverage of full tuition during the tenure of the award, regardless of whether the student's program is base-rate or full for assistantship waivers. The coverage is provided through payment by the funding agency of all tuition assessed or payment of a negotiated institutional allowance in lieu of full payment or a full waiver provided by campus. The Graduate College negotiates the institutional payment with the sponsor. Any exceptions to this policy must be granted by the Graduate College. Tuition income lost due to fellowship or traineeship waiver is not reimbursable. This applies to awards originating on and off-campus.

The minimum fellowship/traineeship stipend amount sufficient to generate a waiver is listed below by academic year. By November of each year, the Graduate College in consultation with the Fellowship Board and approval of the Office of the Provost establishes the minimum fellowship/traineeship stipend sufficient to provide a waiver for new awards for the following academic year. For students with multi-year awards, the minimum stipend amount sufficient to generate a waiver is established in the initial year of the award and remains constant for the duration of that award.

Minimum Stipend per Academic Year	Minimum Stipend per Semester	Minimum Stipend for 12-month Appointment	Minimum Stipend for Summer
$10,000	$5,000	$13,000	$1,111 monthly for 2 months

Campus fellowships and traineeships. Awards funded by campus units must be sufficient to generate a waiver or supplement a waiver-generating appointment as shown in the table above.

External agencies providing fellowship or traineeship support are required to pay the university for the fellow or trainee's full tuition or pay a negotiated institutional allowance in lieu of full payment. The Graduate College negotiates the institutional payment with the sponsor. Any exceptions to this policy must be granted by the Graduate College. The Graduate College decides whether an award is a fellowship.

Endowment-based fellowships established Fall 2010 or later that provide a stipend sufficient to entitle the fellow to a tuition waiver will be required to fund the health service fee and the covered portion of the cost of the health insurance fee.

Courtesy fellowship waivers. Departments may request waivers for individual students who receive a fellowship from outside the university only in cases where the stipend is paid directly to the student, the stipend meets or exceeds the campus established minimum, and the award has no funding for tuition and fees. The student must be in good academic standing. Requests for courtesy waivers must be submitted through the Graduate College's Fellowship Processing System by the student's graduate program and must include specific information on the financial support the award provides. The Graduate College will review the information and determine the

eligibility for a courtesy waiver. Courtesy fellowship waivers may include a waiver of all tuition assessed, as well as the service fee, the health service fee, the Academic Facility Maintenance Fund Assessment (AFMFA) fee, international fee, transportation fee, and the Library/Technology fee. They also provide vision insurance, dental insurance, and partial payment of the health insurance fee. Students receiving courtesy waivers are required to be registered during the terms in which they receive a courtesy waiver according to the registration requirements for fellows.

Other Provisions

For all waiver-generating appointments (assistantships, fellowships, and traineeships), other provisions include the following:

Selection documentation. The Joint Commission on Administrative Rules (JCAR) requires tuition and fee waiver records to be maintained for a minimum of five years. Therefore, awarding units should retain records pertaining to application, evaluation, and selection, including records for rejected applicants for tuition and fee waiver support (waiver-generating fellowships or assistantships, courtesy waivers, or stand-alone waivers).

Fee waivers. Most waiver-generating appointments include coverage of the service fee, health service fee, AFMFA fee, and the Library/Technology fee, transportation fee, and international student fee, if assessed, along with partial payment of the health insurance fee, and full payment by the university for the university vision insurance and dental insurance plans. Note: Some fellowship and traineeship appointments provide coverage of all mandatory fees. College of Law students have an additional Law Library fee. For additional fee information please see the Office of the Registrar's Tuition & Fee Rates by Term web page.

> You can view the semester fee waivers on the Graduate College website.

Waiver priority. The campus has established a priority system to guide the work of the Office of Student Financial Aid in processing waivers in cases where students have more than one waiver-generating appointment or are eligible for waivers from multiple sources. The waiver priorities are as follows:

1. Fellowship waiver
2. Assistantship waiver from an externally funded research assistantship
3. Assistantship waiver from appointing unit within student’s academic college
4. Assistantship waiver from appointing unit outside of student’s academic college

If a student has a waiver-generating fellowship and a waiver-generating assistantship for the same term, the fellowship waiver (full waiver of tuition) will take priority. It is not possible to combine a base-rate graduate

assistant tuition waiver with other partial tuition waivers (such as a waiver of non-resident tuition) to obtain a more complete waiver of tuition. Questions about the waiver priority system can be directed to the Office of Student Financial Aid.

Summer automatic waivers. Students without summer waiver-generating appointments who held waiver-generating appointments for the previous spring semester are eligible to receive summer automatic tuition waivers if they choose to enroll in the summer semester. The summer automatic waiver provides the same tuition waiver as that granted during the previous spring. The summer automatic waiver will also include a waiver of the following fees: Service fee, AFMFA Fee, Library/Technology fee, transportation fee, international student fee (if assessed), 87% of the health insurance fee and full waiver of the health service fee. Students with dental and vision insurance coverage from a waiver-generating appointment in the spring term continue to have dental and vision coverage through August 31. Reimbursable programs are not reimbursed for summer automatic waivers.

Stand-alone waivers. At their discretion, disciplinary colleges may elect to grant a stand-alone waiver to a student who has no waiver-generating appointment. The tuition waiver may be a base-rate or full waiver depending on the graduate program in which the student is enrolled. Stand-alone waivers also include the service fee, AFMFA fee, and Library/Technology fee. No other fees are covered in this waiver nor does it include dental and vision insurance coverage. Colleges may limit the number of stand-alone waivers they will grant.

Exceptions for early termination of assistantship appointment. A student who resigns a waiver-generating assistantship appointment or whose appointment is canceled before service is rendered for at least three-fourths of the academic term (91 days during a spring or fall semester, 41 days in summer term, or 21 days in summer 1 term for TA appointments) loses the accompanying tuition and fee waiver. This means that the student would be required to pay the full amount of appropriate tuition and fees for that term. There are two exceptions:

1. The waiver remains in effect if the student withdraws from the university on or before the last day of the assistantship appointment, or
2. If the student resigns from the assistantship and completes all degree requirements for graduation within seven calendar days of the resignation (for example, completing the deposit of the dissertation within seven calendar days before or after the last date of the assistantship). See Chapter 8.1 Assistantship Policies for more information about resigning assistantships.

Exceptions for early termination of fellowship appointment. Students with waiver-generating fellowships will retain their tuition waiver for the semester if they withdraw from the university on or before the last day of the fellowship appointment, or if they complete all degree requirements within seven calendar days of resigning their fellowship.

Taxability of tuition waivers associated with assistantships and fellowships. All graduate tuition and fee waivers are considered taxable income unless exempt under the Internal Revenue Code (IRC). Current tax law

exempts the tuition and service fee waivers for teaching assistantships (TAs), research assistantships (RAs), and most fellowships. For graduate assistantship (GA) and pre-professional graduate assistantship (PGA) appointments, only $5,250 per calendar year is exempt. If the amount of the tuition and service fee waiver exceeds $5,250, the excess is deemed income under the IRC and additional withholding may be applied.

Each semester, GAs and PGAs whose tuition and service fee waivers to date are valued at more than $5,250 will have withholding on the amount exceeding $5,250. The withholding tax is applied to the student's earnings (stipend or hourly pay).

Waiver Taxibility Resources

- Contact the University Payroll Service Center
- Review IRS Publication 970: Chapters 12 and 13
- See Section 3-503 of the Student Code
- See archived tuition waiver policies on the Graduate College website

7.3 Cost-of-Education Policy

The Council of Deans approved a formal cost-of-education allowance policy for graduate fellowships.

External agencies providing fellowship or traineeship support are required to pay the university for the fellow or trainee's full tuition or pay a negotiated institutional allowance in lieu of full payment. The Graduate College negotiates the institutional payment with the sponsor.

A portion of the cost-of-education allowance or institutional payment negotiated in lieu of full payment of tuition and fees provided to the university by an external sponsor shall be returned to the College in which the student is enrolled. In exchange for the negotiated payment, the university provides the fellow or trainee with full coverage of tuition and all mandatory fees if there are no stipulations to the contrary.

Any exceptions to this policy must be granted by the Dean of the Graduate College. Questions about the policy may be directed to the Graduate College Fellowship Office.

Chapter 8
Assistantships and Fellowships

There are many policies which govern assistantship and fellowship appointments, including those set by the Office of the Provost and other governing bodies on campus. Because students are frequently also employees, they need to be aware of policies set by Illinois Human Resources, and the university's agreement with the Graduate Employee's Organization (GEO). Students should consult and be familiar with campus policies set by the following units as they pertain to assistants and fellows.

Employee Resources

Illinois Human Resources. Administers university policies for employees (including graduate employees), hours of work, stipends, and leaves.

Division of Research Safety. Provides online training that is mandatory for all employees or students working in research labs that have or use biological, chemical, or radiological materials. This training should be completed within the first month of activity in such a lab.

Graduate College Fellowship Office. Helps students and staff understand policies and requirements for assistantships, fellowships, and traineeships. Reach out to the Fellowship Office if you have any questions.

Graduate Employee's Organization (GEO /IFT /AFT /AFL-CIO). Recognized officially as the exclusive bargaining unit for all graduate assistants (GAs) and most teaching assistants (TAs). For assistants represented by GEO, wages, hours, terms, and conditions of employment are included in their Agreement with the University of Illinois (found on the Illinois Human Resources website).

Office of the Provost. Requires that graduate teaching assistants attend training before beginning any teaching appointment. Before the start of classes, departments either conduct training programs for all new teaching assistants or require attendance at the Graduate Academy for College Teaching (which includes sessions about language and culture that meet the university's policy requirements for all non-native English speakers before they begin teaching). For more information, see the Center for Innovation in Teaching & Learning website.

University of Illinois Ethics and Compliance Office. Administers an annual online ethics training program to all employees. The office contacts students via their official university e-mail account during a pre-announced time period with individual login instructions for the training.

> **Vice President of Human Resources.** Administers an annual online Abused and Neglected Child Reporting Act (ANCRA) training program to all employees. The Vice President of Human Resources contacts all employees via their official university e-mail account during a pre-announced time period with individual login instructions for the training.

8.1 Assistantship Policies

The various departments of the university may appoint students as teaching (TA), research (RA), pre-professional graduate (PGA), or graduate assistants (GA). Illinois Human Resources has defined the duties associated with each type of assistantship. Graduate student assistantships and their accompanying tuition waivers provide students with financial resources that help defray the expenses associated with completing their graduate degrees.

Application, Evaluation, and Selection Process

Campus academic departments and administrative units appoint graduate students as assistants. Applicants to the Graduate College request consideration for an assistantship by checking the appropriate box on the application form, and continuing students apply directly to the appropriate department according to its procedures.

The evaluation and selection process for an assistantship appointment is conducted by the department. The documentation related to this process must be retained. The primary considerations for an assistantship appointment are the appropriateness of the student's abilities to the duties to be performed, together with the relevance of those duties to the student's own graduate education. Each unit that makes assistantship appointments is responsible for ensuring that the graduate students are qualified for the appointment received.

> Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy contains additional information regarding the length of time that assistantship application documentation should be retained.

Eligibility Requirements

To receive and hold an assistantship, a student must either be admitted as a degree-seeking student in good standing (Chapter 3.2 Academic Standing) or be admitted to a non-degree program under an exchange agreement that includes an assistantship as part of the terms of the agreement.

Students not in good academic standing, admitted on limited status, or admitted as non-degree students must petition the Graduate College each term to request to hold an assistantship.

Assistantships cannot be offered to students who have graduated unless the student has successfully requested to change curriculum and will continue in another program.

Assistantships cannot be offered to individuals prior to their admission term. If a unit is interested in providing a summer assistantship to a person admitted for fall, the unit must recode the application to indicate summer as the term of admission.

To be eligible for a Teaching Assistantship appointment, individuals must be orally proficient in English. The University of Illinois has established a minimum acceptable score for approved English proficiency exams that is required of all non-native English speakers serving in instructional roles; however, some campus units may require higher scores. There are no exceptions. Students applying for teaching assistantships in foreign language programs are not eligible to seek an exemption from the requirement for demonstrated English proficiency. In addition, campus policy requires those who pass the proficiency exam to attend the Graduate Academy for College Teaching and have their teaching closely monitored by their departments. Additional information may be obtained from the Center for Innovation in Teaching & Learning.

Enrollment Requirements

Fall and spring, all students. In the fall and spring terms, students receiving assistantships must be registered for the semesters of appointment.

Summer, new students. Students admitted for summer term who receive assistantships must register for the summer term.

Summer, current students. If a student receives a summer assistantship (the period between May 16 and August 15), and the student was registered for the immediately preceding spring semester or has registered for the following fall semester, the campus policy does not require the student to register for the summer term; however, the student's department may require summer registration.

Appointment Level

All assistantship appointments must be processed to reflect the actual percentage and length of time the employee works. The appointment level is based on the appointing unit's determination of the amount of time it should normally take to perform the assigned duties over the full appointment period, including orientation and training. Hours of work are separate and distinct from the time required for an assistant's own academic course work.

International students may receive a maximum of a 50 percent assistantship per government regulations, and should check with International Student and Scholar Services for additional rules.

Stipends

The university establishes a campus minimum stipend for assistants and the terms of the University Agreement with the Graduate Employees Organization (GEO) stipulates the minimum for represented assistants. Units may pay above the minimum, and stipend amounts vary from unit to unit. Assistantship stipends are taxable, and state and federal taxes are withheld from stipends. Assistants whose enrollment is deemed to be less than half time will also have Federal Insurance Contributions Act tax (i.e., the Social Security and Medicare deductions) withheld from their stipends.

In addition, the stipend of students holding Graduate Assistantships (GAs) or Pre-Professional Graduate Assistantships (PGAs) will be subject to withholding tax on the value of tuition and service fee waivers that exceed $5,250 per calendar year. Each semester, GAs and PGAs whose tuition and fee waivers to date are valued at more than $5,250 will have withholding on the amount exceeding $5,250 applied to their stipend payments. See Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy for taxability of tuition waivers associated with assistantships and fellowships.

Employment Leaves

Assistants are eligible for holidays, sick leave, parental, and bereavement leave. Review the Illinois Human Resources website for additional information. Questions about leave policies should be directed to Illinois Human Resources.

Teaching of Graduate Level Courses

Teaching assistants may not, either intentionally or by default, be given sole responsibility for instruction of courses or sections of courses at the 400- or 500- levels or for the assignment of final grades in such courses (except 400-level course sections in which enrollment is limited to undergraduates). Teaching assistants may only assist the responsible instructor in grading, laboratory supervision, and similar activities for courses at the 400- or 500-level. Infrequent lecturing is permissible. Departments requesting an exception must provide the Dean of the Graduate College with a letter explaining the special circumstances that justify the exception, including the qualifications (expertise in subject, nearness of date on which the doctorate is expected, etc.,) of the student who is proposed as the teacher (see the guidelines on the Graduate College website). Exceptions are rarely granted. A student is not allowed to enroll in a course in which they are a teaching assistant.

Renewal, Resignation, Degree Completion, and Termination of Appointments

Renewal. Assistantships are ordinarily assigned on a semester-by-semester or academic year-by-year basis. An appointment remains in effect only if the student maintains good academic standing, makes satisfactory academic progress, and provides satisfactory service. Assistants are eligible for reappointment at the sole discretion of the unit based on past performance of the assistant, availability of funds, and the determination of the need for services. Departments are encouraged to communicate with assistants concerning plans or prospects for new appointments. Departments have differing policies on the length of time students may hold assistantships and sometimes limit the total number of semesters an assistant may serve. Many departments require that teaching assistants obtain and maintain certain teaching standards in order for their assistantships to be renewed. It is essential for the student to be aware of the appointing unit's policy and to plan accordingly.

Resignation. A student who resigns a waiver-generating assistantship appointment or whose appointment is canceled before service is rendered for at least three-fourths of the academic term (91 days during a spring or fall semester, 41 days in the summer term, or 21 days in the summer 1 term for TA appointments) loses the accompanying tuition and fee waiver. This means that the student would be required to pay the full amount of appropriate tuition and fees for that term. See Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy for the two exceptions to this policy.

> The minimum days needed for an appointment to generate a waiver can be found at Tuition & Fee Waivers (www.grad.illinois.edu).

Degree completion. Students with assistantship appointments (RA, TA, GA, PGA) are eligible to hold their assistantships through the end of the semester in which they deposit their thesis or dissertation if the end date of the appointment, when offered and accepted, was the same or later than the deposit date. For example, a student with a spring appointment processed to end May 15 may hold the assistantship through May 15, even if the student deposited the thesis any time between January 1 and May 15. This does not obligate the student to continue the assistantship. The campus policy permits students to resign their assistantships and retain their waivers if they complete all degree requirements for graduation within seven calendar days of the resignation, as detailed in Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy. For students with academic year assistantship appointments, their assistantship would end at the end of the semester in which they deposit their thesis or dissertation and may not continue into the next semester.

Termination. An assistantship appointment may be terminated during the term of the appointment. The assistant must be provided with written notice and an opportunity to respond to the department head prior to termination. For more information about procedures for terminating an assistantship appointment, see the Illinois Human Resources. Assistants with questions about their appointments and benefits may also contact the Illinois Human Resources. Teaching assistants and graduate assistants may also consult the GEO Agreement with the University of Illinois.

8.2 Campus Fellowship and Traineeship Policies

A **fellowship** is defined as an award providing a stipend for living expenses at the established minimum or higher and demanding no services in return. Fellowship awards count against student loan eligibility. Fellowship appointments are reviewed in the Graduate College.

Traineeships are research fellowships that are awarded to provide educational training in particular disciplinary areas and provide a stipend for living expenses. Traineeship awards count against student loan eligibility. In questionable cases the Graduate College will decide whether an award is a traineeship.

Students who are admitted on limited status due to grade point average, admitted on limited status due to bachelor's degree not comparable to that at this university, or not in good academic standing may not hold fellowships or traineeships until they are in good academic standing. Non-degree students are not eligible for fellowships or traineeships.

Students not in good academic standing must petition the Graduate College each term to request to hold a fellowship or traineeship.

The full tuition and fee policy for fellows and trainees can be found in Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy.

Registration for Fellows and Trainees

Holders of waiver-generating assistantships/traineeships and holders of courtesy waivers are required to register during their entire fellowship periods and must register full-time during the fall and spring semester.

Award Periods

The standard award period for an academic year fellowship is August 16 to May 15. The standard award period for a fall fellowship is August 16 to December 15; the standard award period for a spring fellowship is January 16 to May 15.

Concurrent Awards

Fellows are generally prohibited from holding two waiver-eligible awards concurrently. An "award" here includes any fellowship, traineeship, grant, tuition payment award, or comparable support from any government agency (state, federal, or foreign), or from any foundation, corporation, or similar organization. "Waiver-eligible" means that the award is of sufficient dollar amount to generate a waiver (see Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy or details on the dollar amounts required to generate a waiver). Any award offer should be reported immediately to the

Graduate College Fellowship Office where the determination will be made as to whether an exception to this policy is allowable.

Concurrent Appointments

Unless otherwise restricted by campus policy, the granting agency or unit, or other external source, fellows may, at the discretion of their department and with the prior approval of the Graduate College, hold up to 67% FTE in totality of assistantship/traineeship appointments. Any assistantship/traineeship offer should be reported to the Graduate College Fellowship Office through its electronic fellowship management system, and the Fellowship Office will then determine whether the appointment can be held concurrently with the fellowship.

Taxability of Stipend

Fellowship stipends may be subject to income taxes. For U.S. citizens, permanent residents, and foreign national resident aliens for tax purposes, the Internal Revenue Service (IRS) has ruled that universities are not responsible for withholding or reporting income taxes on fellowship payments. Taxability of the fellowship payment is a matter between the fellow and the IRS. Therefore, no income taxes are withheld from fellowship payments. Fellows do not receive a Form W-2 for their fellowship income nor does the university report the fellowship payment to either the state or federal government.

The Internal Revenue Service (IRS) requires that universities withhold taxes from the fellowship payments to international students on temporary visas who are classified as non-resident aliens for tax purposes. International students may be able to claim a treaty benefit that exempts the fellowship payment from income tax withholding. All students on temporary visas must schedule a tax status review appointment with the University Payroll Service Center to determine their tax residency status and whether they qualify for tax treaty benefits. At this appointment, University Payroll determines residency and tax status classification. Fellowship stipend payments will be taxed at the highest possible rate until after the tax status review process is completed.

Taxability of Tuition and Fee Waivers

For information about the taxability of tuition and fee waivers associated with fellowships, see Chapter 7.2 Tuition Waiver Policy.

IRS Resources

- For more information on the taxation of fellowships, see IRS Tax Topic 421: Scholarship and Fellowship Grants

> - For more information on taxation for international fellows, consult IRS Publication 519: Tax Guide for Aliens
> - The Tax Information page on the Graduate College website has links to forms and additional information

Thesis Deposit/Graduation for Fellows

Students with fellowship or traineeship appointments must notify the Graduate College Fellowship Office in advance of thesis deposit as it may result in a change in the terms of the fellowship award, including termination.

For students who are depositing a thesis, the fellowship end date is determined considering multiple factors. These include:

- degree conferral date
- deposit deadline
- deposit date
- policies of the fellowship sponsor
- original award period
- payroll processing dates

This may mean that the fellowship would end effective the date of deposit.

For each degree conferral date there is a window of time within which a student may complete the deposit process and keep a fellowship or traineeship until the end of the standard award period for that semester.

The deposit window of time begins on the doctoral degree final exam deadline date and ends on the deposit deadline date for the degree being conferred. Degrees are conferred in May, August, and December. See the academic calendar for conferral dates. An exception to the fellowship end date policy may occur when a student deposits a master's thesis, but continues as a doctoral student with funding approval from the sponsor. In all cases, the Graduate College Fellowship Office determines the fellowship end date.

Chapter 9
Conflict Resolution and Grievance Policy for Graduate Students

The Graduate College and the University of Illinois have established policies and standards for academic, professional, and personal conduct. Students are responsible for being familiar with these policies and standards (see the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research and Innovation, the Dean of Students, and the Student Code). Conduct that violates these policies and standards may result in serious consequences including dismissal. In addition to the information in this chapter, also see the Graduate College website for resources on problem solving and conflict mediation.

Academic Integrity

Coursework-based charges of academic integrity infractions against graduate students will be handled according to applicable procedures in the Student Code. The Graduate College and the Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research and Innovation work collaboratively to ensure commitment to principles of academic integrity and responsible scholarly conduct. Several campus policies outline ethical and professional standards applying to faculty, students, and staff, and prescribe procedures to be followed when unethical conduct may have occurred.

The term “intellectual property” refers to property that includes patents, copyrights, trade secrets, and trademarks. Any individual using university facilities, equipment, funds, or resources needs to be aware of university policies and procedures related to sponsored research and intellectual property issues, including rights to inventions and copyrightable works developed at the university. Students should also see Chapter 4.2 Graduation Requirements for more details about patents and copyrights related to theses.

Resources

Students should be familiar with the following resources on academic integrity and professional conduct:

- Graduate College Bylaws
- Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC)
- Institutional Review Board Regulation and Policies for human subjects research
- Illinois Human Resources’ Staff Handbook
- The Student Code
- University of Illinois Policy and Procedures on Academic Integrity in Research and Publication

- For additional information about intellectual property, consult the Office of Technology Management

Grievance Policy and Procedures

Some graduate programs have established grievance procedures and students should be aware of whether their program has such a procedure in place. The Graduate College has a grievance policy and procedure in place to assist students and programs. A student may elect to file a formal grievance within the unit in which a problem has arisen if the department has a written grievance procedure approved by the Graduate College. The student may also choose to file the grievance directly with the Graduate College. Students should be aware of differences between the Graduate College and departmental grievance policies, as well as what types of grievances are appropriately addressed by these policies.

All graduate students may use the Graduate College Grievance Policy to file a grievance. Students in the following programs may choose to file a grievance at the departmental level, following the procedures of that unit's grievance policy (see 9.2 Overview of the Graduate College Grievance Process): Anthropology, Civil and Environmental Engineering, Communication, French, Materials Science and Engineering, and Political Science.

9.1 Avenues for Resolution

The university has procedures to provide assistance to students experiencing conflict. Policies and procedures for conflict resolution are overseen by several offices on campus, including the Graduate College, the Office of the Dean of Students, International Student and Scholar Services, the Office of Access and Equity, and, in some cases, individual departments. The type of conflict will determine from which university office(s) the student should seek assistance.

Academic Conflict

Academic conflict may be addressed through informal processes or through a formal grievance process. It is recommended that students first explore the option of informally resolving an academic conflict. A student who believes they have an academic grievance should first discuss it with their adviser. If discussion with the adviser is inappropriate or unfruitful, discussion with a senior faculty member, director of graduate study, or a department or unit head is recommended.

Employment Conflict

Most conflicts between a supervisor and a student can be prevented if the student is given a clear description of responsibilities and expectation for performance and if the student receives regular supervision and evaluation. When a serious conflict between an assistant and a supervisor occurs, reasonable attempts should be made to resolve the conflict informally. If there is a conflict between a supervisor and an assistant that cannot be resolved by informal means, additional resources for students experiencing employment-related conflict include the following:

- the Policy and Procedures for Addressing Discrimination and Harassment at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign,
- the Agreement by and between The Board of Trustees of the University of Illinois and the Graduate Employees' Organization (GEO) (for graduate assistants that are covered); and
- the Illinois Human Resources Office.

Grievances Alleging Discrimination

See Article 1, Part 1 of the Student Code for information on grievances alleging discrimination. Students may also reach out to the Office for Access and Equity, the Title VI Office, or the Title IX Office for additional support.

Capricious Grading

See section 3-107 of the Student Code for information on capricious grading and the departmental procedures for investigating capricious grading complaints.

University Discipline System

See section 1-301 of the Student Code for an outline of the jurisdiction of the university discipline system. The Subcommittee on Graduate Student Conduct of the Senate Committee on Student Discipline has the right to impose sanctions including, but not limited to dismissal, suspension, conduct probation, censure, and reprimand.

Sexual Misconduct

The University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign prohibits sex discrimination in any education program or activity that it operates. Individuals may report concerns or questions to the Title IX Coordinator. The Title IX notice of nondiscrimination is located at **https://go.uillinois.edu/StatementonSexDiscrimination**.

Petitions

The policies, requirements, and deadlines of the Graduate College have been put in place to uphold high academic standards. Exceptions may be justified under extenuating circumstances. Students who wish to request an exception to Graduate College policies may submit a petition providing an explanation or justification

for the action requested. The more unusual or major the request, the more detailed the explanation should be from the student and the adviser and/or other appropriate members of the Graduate Faculty or staff.

9.2 Overview of the Graduate College Grievance Process

A. General Campus Resources

University policy strongly encourages all students who believe they have a dispute or conflict to use all appropriate avenues for informal resolution before initiating the Graduate College grievance process described herein. Students may seek advice about how to address their situation informally from their faculty advisers, their director of graduate studies, their unit executive officer, the Graduate College, the Office of the Dean of Students, and International Student & Scholar Services before pursuing a formal Graduate College grievance.

B. Departmental Grievance

A student may elect to pursue a grievance with the student's department/unit, if the department has a written grievance policy which has been approved by the Dean of the Graduate College.

- **Appeal.** A party dissatisfied with the outcome of a department/unit grievance finding may appeal the decision on procedural grounds to the Graduate College. An appeal must be filed in writing with an Intake Dean within ten business days of the date of the departmental decision being appealed (see 9.3 Procedures for Pursuing a Graduate College Grievance).
- **Reporting.** The department/unit shall annually report to the Graduate College Dean the number of grievances filed under the departmental procedures.

C. Graduate College Grievance

A. Purpose All members of the university community are expected to observe high standards of professional conduct and ethical behavior in graduate education. In a large and heterogeneous scholarly community, problems may emerge among students, faculty, and administrators. The purpose of this policy is to outline the process through which graduate students can constructively address concerns about the decisions or behaviors of faculty or administrators that they believe have adversely affected their status as a graduate student.

B. Availability This policy is available to all current graduate students of the Graduate College. It is also available to former graduate students provided they meet the timeliness requirements specified herein.

C. Applicability This policy applies when a graduate student believes that an incorrect or inappropriate decision or behavior of a faculty member or administrator has adversely affected the student's status. Examples include,

but are not limited to:

- failure to follow a departmental or Graduate College policy in a manner that results in significant prejudice against the student;
- failure to follow departmental or Graduate College procedures for assessing degree milestones such as qualifying examinations, comprehensive examinations, preliminary examinations, recitals, etc.;
- improper termination from a program;
- requiring personal services unrelated to academic duties;
- retaliation for exercising grievance rights.

This policy does not apply in cases involving:

- challenges to Graduate College petition decisions;
- the exercise of professional judgment in evaluating student academic performance/progress;
- student-to-student conflicts;
- academic misconduct such as breaches of academic integrity in research and publication;
- employment-specific issues, including those covered by collective bargaining agreements (i.e., teaching assistantships and administrative graduate assistantships);
- cases that arise under the Student Code, including academic integrity or capricious grading claims;
- cases involving alleged discrimination or sexual harassment.

D. Non-Exclusivity This policy does not override or supersede any other policies or procedures as established in the university Statutes and campus policies.

E. Duty to Cooperate Students availing themselves of the grievance process,and all faculty, staff, and administrators have a duty to cooperate and provide information and materials relevant to the investigation of a grievance. It shall always be the responsibility of the Parties to ensure that the Graduate College has accurate contact information to facilitate communications as described in these procedures.

9.3 Procedures for Pursuing a Graduate College Grievance

A. Informal Resolution

A graduate student wishing to initiate the Graduate College grievance process must start with an Intake Dean. The student will meet with an Intake Dean who will review the matter and materials and attempt to assist the student in resolving the issue at the informal level through discussion or mediation. This process must be initiated within sixty business days of the decision or behavior resulting in the grievance. The Intake Dean may attempt to mediate a resolution for matters that do not meet the deadline, but such matters will not be submitted for a formal review under 9.3.C Formal Review of Unresolved Grievances.

B. Administrative Action

Written grievance. A student may file a written grievance:

- if an informal resolution is unsuccessful, provided the written grievance is filed within ten business days of the date the Intake Dean advises the Grievant and the Subject that no further efforts will be made at the informal stage; or
- to appeal a departmental grievance decision, provided the written grievance is filed within ten business days of the date of the departmental grievance decision being appealed.

Content and submission of grievance. The written grievance should include at least the following:

- a statement by the student summarizing the concern(s)
- the name(s) of the university faculty, staff, or administrators involved
- the date(s) of the alleged incident(s)
- a statement concerning what outcome or action the student would like to see result from the grievance

The grievance should be delivered to the Graduate College Dean.

Handling. Once a written grievance has been submitted and reviewed, the Intake Dean will contact the student to arrange a meeting to discuss it. The Intake Dean will review the written grievance and supporting documentation provided by the Grievant and may conduct further inquiries and/or solicit additional information as warranted. The Intake Dean may facilitate additional discussions between the Parties to try to resolve the matter at the administrative level.

Outcomes.

- **Agreed disposition.** If the Intake Dean is successful in resolving the matter by agreement, the Intake Dean shall prepare a report which includes: 1) the grievance(s), 2) the response(s), 3) the finding(s), and 4) the resolution.

- **Unresolved grievance.** If the Intake Dean is unsuccessful in resolving the matter by agreement, the Intake Dean shall prepare a report which includes: 1) the grievance(s), 2) the response(s), 3) the findings, and 4) what efforts were taken or proposed to resolve the matter administratively.

Report distribution. The reports referenced under outcomes will be submitted to the Dean with copies to the Grievant and the Subject(s) of the Grievance.

Request for formal review. The Grievant or the Subject(s) may request a formal review of unresolved grievances by submitting the Request within ten business days from the date of the Intake Dean's Report to the Dean.

C. Formal Review of Unresolved Grievances

Review of request by Dean. Upon receipt of a request for formal review, the Dean will review the request along with the Intake Dean's Report of Administrative Action and other relevant materials to consider whether any issues merit further investigation and review. If the grievance is declined, the Dean will notify the person seeking review in writing and explain the decision. The Dean's decision is final.

Appointment of review panel. If the Grievance is accepted, the Dean shall appoint a panel of five people to investigate the matter and provide recommendations. The Panel shall consist of one member of the Graduate College Executive Committee, one faculty member from the unit in which the matter originated, one faculty member at large, and two active graduate students at large. The faculty member at large will chair the Panel.

Written Charge.

In general. The Dean shall define the subject matter of the review in a written charge. The charge may but need not address every allegation contained in the request for Formal Review. The charge may also include additional matters that, in the opinion of the Dean, warrant investigation. The charge shall be provided to the Panel, Review Dean (who may or may not be the same person as the Intake Dean), and the Parties to the Grievance.

Content. The written charge shall also include:

- the identities of the Panel members and a statement that either party may challenge a Panel member on the grounds of a conflict of interest within five business days of receipt of the Written Charge;
- a statement that both parties may submit any additional materials relevant to the Written Charge that they want considered by the Panel within ten business days of receipt of the Written Charge; and
- a statement that a Party must make a written request for a meeting with the Panel within ten business days of receipt of the Written Charge if such a meeting is desired, and that the Panel will decide if a meeting is warranted.

Conflict of interest. If the Dean believes a legitimate conflict of interest exists, the Dean will replace the Panel member as appropriate.

Preliminary review panel session(s). After the time granted to the Parties to provide additional materials, the Review Dean shall convene the Panel Members to:

- review the process, discuss the Written Charge and review the materials received during the Administrative Action and pursuant to the materials provided by the parties in response to the Written Charge;
- review any requests for a meeting and decide if a meeting would be helpful in making findings and recommendations regarding the Written Charge;
- provide direction on whether it wants the Review Dean to seek any additional information relevant to the Written Charge from any of the parties or other sources; and
- confirm that the Review Dean has provided copies of written materials received by the Panel to all Parties to the Grievance.

Meeting notice. If the Panel concludes a meeting is necessary, the Review Dean shall send notice of a meeting no fewer than five business days prior to the meeting. The notice must include the date, place and time of the meeting, and a statement that each party may have a Consultant present at the meeting. Continuances may be granted by the Panel Chair with good cause shown.

Meeting attendance. Attendance is restricted to the Grievant, Subject(s) and their respective Consultants, Panel members, the Review Dean, and if necessary, a representative from the Office of University Counsel. If oral statements from witnesses will be received, the witness may be present only while making the statement or responding to questions. Both Parties may be present throughout the meeting but this is not required. Any person, including a Party, who disrupts a meeting or who fails to adhere to the directives of the Chair may be removed from the meeting.

Meeting purpose and structure. The purpose of a meeting under this policy is to allow the Panel to hear directly from the Grievant, Subject(s), and witnesses in order to better attempt to resolve the dispute. While there may be adversarial components, the meeting is not intended to be a trial. Formal rules of evidence shall not apply. All Parties shall treat each other with dignity and respect. Parties may each make a brief opening statement, and then respond to questions from the Panel. The Parties may suggest questions to be asked of each other. The Chair shall decide whether or not to pose the questions. If witnesses will be called, each Party may ask questions directly of their witness, but it will be in the Chair's discretion whether or not questions to another's party's witnesses will be through the Chair or directly by the Party. The confidentiality of all information shall be preserved.

Deliberations. The deliberations of the Panel are confidential. All Parties shall be excluded during the Panel's deliberations. The conclusions and recommendations of the Panel must be agreed to by a simple majority of the Panel hearing the matter. The conclusions and recommendations of the Panel must be based on a preponderance of the evidence (more probably true than not true).

Panel report. The Panel shall submit a written report to the Dean as soon as practical that includes at least the following:

- a copy of the Written Charge from the Dean;
- a statement of the relief sought by the Grievant;
- the response of the Subjects;
- general description of the investigative process;
- a citation of relevant policies;
- findings of fact that support the Panel's conclusions;
- a recommendation of appropriate redress for the Grievant(s), if applicable; and
- any recommended changes in policies and procedures to minimize the probability of recurrence, if applicable.

Opportunity to comment. Copies of the Report shall be provided to the Parties. A party may submit written comments to the Dean of the Graduate College concerning the Report to the Dean within five business days of receipt of the Report.

Action and disposition of the grievance and disclosures. As soon as practical following the receipt of the Report and all written comments concerning the Report, the Dean shall determine what disposition to make of the case.

- If the Dean concludes that the grievance has not been proved, the grievance will be deemed not sustained and dismissed.
- If the Dean concludes that the grievance has been sustained, the Dean will proceed in accordance with the university *Statutes* and relevant university rules and regulations. The Dean may prescribe redress for the grievant, recommend modification of policies, or recommend changes in the procedures for implementation of such policies, as appropriate.
- If the Dean concludes that these procedures have not been followed, or the interests of fairness or thoroughness require further investigation, the Dean may direct the Panel to revisit any relevant issues and submit a revised Report within a certain time frame. The Dean shall identify the specific errors or concerns

and provide direction to the Panel as to appropriate corrective measures. The Panel will only address the issues raised by the Dean and submit a supplemental report to the Dean for consideration.

- The Final Disposition shall be provided to the Parties in writing. The Dean's disposition is final unless appealed as provided for herein. The Dean may authorize the release of a copy of the Disposition on a need to know basis with due regard for privacy rights of employees and students under federal and state law and university policy (see also, 9.4.F Confidentiality).

Appeal. A party may file an appeal to the Provost within ten business days from the date of the Dean's Written Disposition. The sole grounds for appeal are material violations of these procedures that have resulted in significant prejudice against the Party appealing. The appeal must be in writing and must specify the nature of the procedural error. The Provost's decision on appeal shall be final.

9.4 General Provisions

A. Record Keeping and Reporting

After completion of a grievance review and exhaustion of available appeals, the Review Dean shall return any original documents and materials to the persons who furnished them. The Graduate College grievance file is subject to destruction on a date six years beyond the grievant's time limit for completion of the degree. Departments/units that handle department level grievances shall annually report to the Dean the number of grievances filed under the departmental procedures.

B. Interim Action

At any time after a grievance has been filed and before final disposition of the case, the Dean, with the approval of the Provost, may take interim administrative action determined to best serve the interest of the Grievant, other students in the same academic unit, or the Subject in order to protect the best interest of the university, to preserve evidence, or to protect resources.

C. Consultation with Legal Counsel

The Graduate College may consult the Office of University Counsel at any time during the informal or formal processing of a grievance.

D. Timeliness and Procedural Changes

All actions prescribed in this document should be conducted expeditiously. Every effort should be made to resolve a grievance within one year of the beginning of Administrative Action. Extensions of time periods

specified in this document may be granted by the Intake Dean, Panel Chair, or Dean as the case may be, with good cause shown. The Dean may make other reasonable alterations of the procedures set forth in this document, provided that the alteration does not impair the ability of a Grievant to pursue a grievance or the Subjects to respond. Any alterations of these procedures must be communicated to the Parties.

E. Failure to Participate, Withdrawal, and Termination

The grievance may proceed regardless of the failure of the Grievant or Subject(s) to participate, so long as all required notices have been given. The Grievant may submit a written request to withdraw the grievance at any time; however, the Dean shall have the sole discretion to decide whether to grant or deny the request. Withdrawal from the university by the Grievant or termination of employment by the Subject at the university shall not necessarily terminate the proceedings.

F. Confidentiality

All persons involved in administering this policy shall exercise diligent efforts to keep information received or learned during the course of a grievance as confidential. Nothing in these provisions alters privacy rights of employees and students provided in federal and state laws and university policies and procedures. Notwithstanding the foregoing, in the event the Dean concludes that a student has knowingly filed a false grievance, the Dean may authorize the release and use of all materials submitted in this process for use in any disciplinary proceedings.

9.5 Grievance Policy Definitions

Business Day: Monday through Friday, excluding university and campus holidays and reduced service days.

Conflict of Interest: A conflict of interest is a significant professional or personal involvement with the facts or the Parties to a dispute. Any party or administrator who has a conflict of interest in a dispute under this policy or a concern about a conflict on the part of another shall promptly report it to the Intake Dean. The Intake Dean shall refer the matter to the Dean, who shall decide how to address any conflict of interest, unless the conflict lies with the Dean, in which case, the alleged conflict will be referred to the Office of the Provost for resolution.

Consultant: A person intended to provide advice to a Grievant or the Subject of a grievance. The Consultant shall not directly participate in any proceedings, but may be consulted during the process. If any party's consultant at any meeting is an attorney, all participants must be informed at least three business days prior to such a meeting.

Dean: The Dean of the Graduate College or their designee. The Dean has responsibility for graduate programs and related policies and procedures. The Dean is the final arbiter of disputes under this policy. In the event a

grievance is filed against the Dean, these responsibilities shall be referred to the Office of the Provost for handling and any appeals will be to the Chancellor or their designee.

Grievant: The student in the Graduate College who has filed a grievance.

Intake Dean: A person who has been identified by the Dean to handle a particular dispute; usually an assistant or associate dean in the Graduate College. The Intake Dean will, as appropriate, facilitate informal discussions and/or mediation of disputes; receive information and facilitate discussions and/or mediation after a grievance has been filed at the administrative action stage; prepare a written report of the efforts to resolve the matter; and provide this and other relevant background information as needed to the Review Dean, if different from the Intake Dean.

Parties: Refers to the Grievant and all Subjects named in a grievance collectively.

Review Dean: A person who the Dean may identify to oversee the formal review process; usually an assistant or associate dean in the Graduate College who may be the same person as the Intake Dean. The Review Dean is responsible for providing administrative support for the Review Panel, maintaining documentation, and keeping the Parties informed as to the status of a grievance.

Subject(s): The person or persons named in the grievance. If a grievance generally references a department or unit, the Subject shall be the director or head of the department or unit.

Part 2: Program Administration Policies

Chapter 10
Graduate Faculty Membership

The Graduate Faculty are faculty members who support graduate students through mentorship, serving on doctoral committees, and teaching graduate courses. All faculty members who are appointed to a tenure or tenure-track position are members of the Graduate Faculty. Others may be nominated for term membership; these requests are reviewed by the Graduate College.

10.1 Policy and Responsibilities

The Graduate College has jurisdiction over all programs leading to graduate degrees.

As defined in the university *Statutes* (Article V, Section 1c), “The faculty of the Graduate College consists of the President, the Chancellor/Vice President, the Provost or equivalent officer, the Dean, and all those who on the recommendation of the department or of other teaching or research divisions have been approved by the Executive Committee and the Dean of the Graduate College to assume appropriate academic responsibilities in programs leading to graduate degrees. Other administrative staff members are members of the faculty of the Graduate College only if they also hold faculty appointments and have been recommended and approved as provided above.”

These academic responsibilities include:

- establishing and maintaining high quality graduate education and research programs within the academic units of the university;
- developing and teaching of graduate level courses and curricula;
- advising graduate students;
- serving on doctoral examination committees as a member, director of research, or chair;

- electing members of the Graduate College Executive Committee;
- serving on Graduate College committees; and
- providing advice to the Graduate College Dean and the Executive Committee.

The Graduate College recognizes that the standards of academic excellence must remain at the highest level consistent with individual unit standards. Standards shall be maintained without discriminating against a faculty member on unlawful grounds and without limiting the University of Illinois' guarantee of academic freedom and equal opportunity.

10.2 Membership Criteria and Procedures

To carry out the statutory charge to the Graduate College "to develop and safeguard standards of graduate work and to promote and assist in the advancement of research in all fields" (*Statutes*, Article V, Section 1a), the Dean, with the advice of the Executive Committee, establishes standards for membership in the Graduate College, monitors their implementation, and retains responsibility for appointments to the Graduate Faculty. These standards assume that:

- faculty members appointed to units offering programs leading to graduate degrees meet the highest standards of the discipline for graduate teaching and research or for creative activity;
- those faculty members are given freedom, opportunity, and guidance to become involved in graduate
- education, and to participate to the fullest extent of their interests and capabilities in the affairs of the Graduate College; and
- the executive officer of the unit is committed to consistent high quality achievements of the faculty, accomplished through their active participation in the unit's graduate programs.

Appointment Criteria and Procedures

- Each faculty member shall be recommended automatically for membership in the Graduate Faculty and shall be appointed by the Dean at the time of appointment or promotion to a tenure-track or tenured position.
- Others may be nominated by the unit executive officer for term membership on the Graduate Faculty if the qualifications of the nominee as judged by the Executive Committee and the Dean are comparable to those required for appointment to a tenure-track position. The initial term may be at most five years.

Extending Membership

- Members of the Graduate Faculty who have retired or resigned may be retained on the Graduate Faculty for up to five years, upon request by the unit executive officer or other authorized individual. The Graduate College recommends, but does not require, that these faculty members have adjunct or emeriti/ae appointments.
- Members of the Graduate Faculty who retired or resigned with tenure may retain Graduate Faculty membership and tenure status only for the purpose of serving on doctoral committees for a period of up to five years following their resignation or retirement upon the request of the unit executive officer or other authorized individual. That period may be extended at the request of the unit executive officer, so long as the faculty member remains actively involved in the graduate program.
- Members of the Graduate Faculty whose terms have ended may be renewed for up to five years upon request by the unit executive officer or other authorized individual.

Ending Membership

- A Graduate Faculty member may resign from the Graduate Faculty voluntarily by submitting a letter of resignation to the dean of the Graduate College.
- A Graduate Faculty member who resigns or retires from the university is automatically removed from membership in the Graduate Faculty unless the unit asks that the Faculty member continue for a specified period of time.
- A unit may submit a request to the Graduate College to have a member removed from the Graduate Faculty if the member has been grossly neglectful of or grossly inefficient in the performance of responsibilities as a Graduate Faculty member (as listed in the introduction to this policy). The written request for removal must be made by the unit executive officer to the Dean of the Graduate College and must state reasons. The Faculty member under consideration for removal may provide a written statement requesting continued membership.
- The unit’s request and the Faculty statement, if submitted, will be considered by the Graduate College Executive Committee, which shall make a recommendation to the Dean of the Graduate College. The Dean shall make the decision on removal, which may be appealed to the Provost and Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs.

Chapter 11
Policy for Proposed New and Revised Courses that Carry Graduate Credit

As one mechanism for fulfilling the statutory function of the Graduate College to “develop and safeguard standards of graduate work,” the Dean of the Graduate College and the Executive Committee review all proposed new courses and revisions of courses that carry graduate credit. Detailed review of proposals is handled in one of two ways, which are outlined in this chapter.

Criteria by which proposals for graduate courses are judged and procedures by which they are reviewed are described below. Faculty members are encouraged to consult with Graduate College deans for advice in preparing course proposals. The checklist of criteria is minimal, and is not intended to be exhaustive. The diversity of programs and the wide variety of courses necessitate, in many cases, judgments based in part on the standards of an individual discipline and are usually made by faculty in that discipline. There is no intent to eliminate judgment by reducing the criteria to an inflexible set of rules. However, proposers are encouraged to offer specific explanations whenever their proposals deviate from the general criteria.

Criteria for Graduate Courses

1. Course content should be intellectually challenging to graduate students.
2. Course subject matter should have a strong emphasis on the literature of the discipline(s) and/or should draw actively from the latest relevant research and scholarly activity.
3. A course for graduate credit should usually build on knowledge previously gained or, unusually, on equivalent experience. Admission criteria should be carefully specified as to background required (e.g., prior study, courses completed, level of creative accomplishment). The prerequisites will also be evaluated as to appropriateness to the content and rigor of each course.
4. A graduate course must bear a logical relationship to the total offerings of a department or to other courses in an area of specialization within the discipline.
5. Course content should not needlessly duplicate or overlap substantially that of other courses in the department or in other departments. If the course overlaps significantly with a course in another department, it might still be offered independently; however a supporting letter explaining how the courses differ in purpose and content must be attached. A single cross-listed course may meet the needs of students in several departments, wherein the interdisciplinary review of the subject may benefit both the students and the instructors. Other factors will be considered, such as level of the course, background of the students, and the emphasis of the course in evaluating duplication and overlap of course content.

6. The graduate credit offered should be appropriate to the nature of the course and to the extent of work required of graduate students and how it will be factored into the final grade.

Graduate Course Credit and Contact Hour Expectations

A. Credit

Course proposals should justify why the course warrants graduate credit in terms of level of content, previous knowledge required, relevance to current research, methodology, etc.

If credit for graduate students is different than credit for undergraduate students, the extra work required should be of a concrete nature, included in calculation of the final grade, and listed explicitly. For example, in a class with 3 hours of undergraduate credit and 4 hours of graduate credit, it is necessary to state, “graduate students must lead one class discussion, write weekly summaries that will be graded, and turn in a 25-page paper instead of a 15-page paper,” than to simply say, “graduate students will be held to demonstrating graduate level depth in class discussions and assignments.” Demonstration of graduate-level depth in class discussions and assignments, however, should be expected of graduate students if credit for graduate and undergraduate students is equal.

If variable credit is to be offered to graduate students, e.g., 3 or 4 hours, the higher credit should be justified by describing the extra work required and how it will be factored into the final grade.

B. Contact hours

The Graduate College has not established rigid ratios between course credit hours and class contact hours. However, in recognition of desired variability associated with subject matter and modes of teaching, the following issues are relevant for consideration:

- The number of class contact hours in organized instruction between instructor and student is one factor affecting the quality of instruction. It is customary for graduate courses that carry either 3 or 4 hours of credit to meet in organized instruction for 43 to 58 contact hours per term (3 to 4 contact hours per week in fall or spring) including examinations. These ratios should be observed for organized instruction, which excludes laboratory, independent study, special problems, and thesis research courses. An additional laboratory that meets for two to three hours per week can justify one additional hour of credit.
- Substantial deviation from these ratios should be justified by the department proposing the course. Each case will be judged on its merits as detailed in the course proposal.

Contact Hours

The distinction between a contact hour and a clock hour is as follows:

A class contact hour is defined as one 50-minute session, that is, the traditional meeting time within a clock hour, allowing for the mandatory 10-minute passing period beginning at X:50 of the hour.

If a class session extends past one clock hour, or meets “off-clock,” the total session minutes divided by 50 determines the contact hours for the session. Thus, three 50-minute or two 75-minute sessions per week constitute three contact hours per week.

C. Review Procedures

1. Role of the department, school, and college courses and curricula committees.

   The review and approval of all appropriate committees is required before a course proposal will be reviewed by the Graduate College.

   - The course proposal must be approved by the head of the department. The faculty members who prepared the request and will teach the course should be identified.
   - A courses and curricula committee in the school (if applicable) and college must have reviewed and approved the course proposal.
   - The proposal must be reviewed and approved by all cross listed units, as well as their school (if applicable) and academic colleges, if different, prior to review by the Graduate College.
   - The college courses and curricula committee must provide a report of its evaluation. If the substantive review of courses is conducted by a unit other than the college, (e.g., certain independent schools and institutes), those units should also submit a report of their evaluation.

2. Administrative review in the Graduate College

   If the college-level courses and curriculum committee verifies that a course meets the six Graduate College criteria listed above, then the course may be approved administratively by a dean within the Graduate College.

3. Review by the Graduate College Executive Committee

Courses that have not gone through a two-tiered committee approval process will be reviewed by the Graduate College Executive Committee, prior to Graduate College approval.

Chapter 12
Graduate College Policy for the Approval of New and Revised Graduate Degree Programs

Review and approval of all proposed new and revised graduate degree programs by the Dean and Executive Committee of the Graduate College are required, as one mechanism for fulfilling the statutory functions of the Graduate College to "develop and safeguard standards of graduate work." Criteria by which proposals for graduate programs are judged by Graduate College committees and the reviews required are described below.

Recognizing the diversity of graduate programs on campus, the criteria are deliberately general to permit flexibility in evaluation of programs by the standards of the discipline.

Procedures to assist in creating and structuring a proposal and more details regarding the processing of approvals are available online in the Graduate College Faculty and Staff Canvas Community.

12.1 Graduate Degree Programs

A. Master's Degrees

In a university where the emphasis is on the research PhD, there is wide variety in the objectives and organization of master's degrees. In general they fall into two categories:

- Those leading to the academic degrees of Master of Arts (M.A.) or Master of Science (M.S.) and are an introduction to scholarly activities and research for the PhD
- Professional master's programs that prepare graduates for careers outside the academy, such as teachers or practitioners.

B. Doctoral Programs

The traditional Doctor of Philosophy is a rigorous research degree.

In place of or supplementing the research component, professional doctoral programs usually contain more coursework or professional experience in the form of doctoral projects or practica.

C. Certificate of Advanced Study

A terminal degree beyond the master's degree for those professionals seeking further course-based education, but not intending to continue for a research doctorate.

D. Graduate Certificates

The Graduate Certificate is a transcripted post-baccalaureate credential designed to allow prospective students the opportunity to enhance their skills and career potential through a coherent set of courses focused on a specific subject. See Chapter 6 Requirements for Doctoral Degrees for more information.

12.2 Master's Degree Programs

A. Criteria for Master's Programs

Because of the variety in master's degrees' objectives, it is difficult to set criteria that are appropriate for all programs. The following are criteria that should guide judgment with recognition of standards of the discipline and objectives of the particular master's program.

- A master's program should encompass a well-defined and recognized area of advanced study based on an established body of knowledge.
- A master's program should consist of a coherent pattern of courses, which, at the unit's discretion, may be capped by a comprehensive examination, a thesis or project report, or a creative project. The unit has the option of requiring a final evaluation and determining its form if required.
- The relation of the master's program to other graduate programs in the unit, particularly to doctoral degree programs, should be clearly defined. There should also be a defined and complementary relation to other master's programs on the campus; unnecessary duplication should be avoided.
- A core faculty of demonstrated experience and achievement in teaching and research in the field should be available and committed to conducting the master's program.
- Typically, the core faculty should be members of the Graduate Faculty. Evidence of scholarly productivity through publication or of creative achievement through performances and exhibits should be presented.
- The core faculty should be sufficient in number to teach the graduate courses and supervise the research connected with a thesis or project if required.
- The demand for graduates of the program should be addressed in the proposal, but the demand should not be the primary criterion for measuring the need for a master's program.
- There should be evidence of a potential clientele of qualified students for the master's program.

- There should be evidence that the proposing unit has the resources, available or committed, to mount a master's program without diluting existing programs. The resources should be sufficient to support the necessary facilities, e.g., library, computer, laboratory, and so forth.
- A proposal for a new or substantially revised program should compare the proposed requirements with those of similar programs at peer institutions.
- The proposed master's program must meet the minimum requirements for master's programs for admission, credit, residence, and so forth, as stated in this handbook.

B. Requirements for Master's Programs

A master's degree program must require at least 32 hours. Usually, a professional master's program requires more than 32 hours of credit. The proportion of course work to thesis research credit is determined by the department.

Every master's program must include at least 12 hours of 500-level courses, and at least 8 of these 12 hours must be in the major field. A department may determine the number of hours of thesis (599) that may count toward the 500-level requirement.

12.3 Doctoral Degree Programs

A. Criteria for Doctoral Programs

- A doctoral program should contribute to the broad mission of the university.
- There should be a defined and complementary relation of the proposed doctoral program to other graduate programs on the campus, and in the case of a new degree, to other degrees in the unit.
- A doctoral program should derive from a body of knowledge established over a sufficient period to develop a substantial scholarly discipline of well-defined content, in a field of reasonable depth.
- A core faculty of demonstrated experience and achievement in graduate teaching and research should be available and committed to conducting the doctoral program.
- Normally, all of the core faculty should be members of the Graduate Faculty and a substantial proportion should have tenure. Evidence of scholarly productivity through publication or creative achievement through performances or exhibits should be presented.
- The core faculty should be sufficient in number to teach the graduate courses and conduct and supervise the research.
- The need for a doctoral program in the discipline should be demonstrated in terms of the potential contribution of its graduates to education, research, public service, or private enterprise.

- The demand for graduates of the program should be addressed in the proposal, but demand should not be the primary criterion for measuring the need for a doctoral program.
- There should be evidence of a potential clientele of qualified students for the doctoral program.
- There should be evidence that the proposing unit has the resources, available or committed, to mount a doctoral program, without diluting ongoing programs. The resources should be sufficient to support the necessary facilities, e.g., library, computer, laboratory, and so forth.
- A proposal for a new program should compare the proposed requirements with those of similar programs at peer institutions.
- The proposed doctoral program must meet the minimum requirements of the Graduate College for admission, credit, doctoral examinations, dissertation, and so forth, as stated in this handbook.

B. Requirements for PhD Programs

The PhD is a research degree. The unit proposing a PhD should have in place or under development a strong program of research and scholarship. A rigorous research component should be required in the graduate program.

A PhD program requires at least 96 hours of credit, divided into three stages. A doctoral student is considered to be in Stage I from initial enrollment in the Graduate College to completion of the master's degree or its equivalent, namely at least 32 hours of graduate work here or at another university. Stage I ends with an evaluation of the student's progress toward the doctoral degree, by examination or other formal review procedure. A doctoral student is considered to be in Stage II from completion of the master's degree or equivalent to completion of all departmental requirements (except the defense and deposit of the dissertation), including passing the preliminary examination. Stage III is the time from the completion of Stage II to passing of the final defense and deposit of an approved dissertation, and consists of research and other activities.

C. Requirements for Other Doctoral Programs

Other doctoral degree programs must be judged by the above criteria, where appropriate, as well as the special criteria of the profession and the discipline.

12.4 Revised Graduate Programs

The Graduate College Executive Committee should review and approve proposals for all major revisions of graduate degree programs. Minor revisions to programs may not require approval beyond the Graduate College. Substantial revisions will require approval beyond the Graduate College. To determine the degree of changes that

are proposed and the approvals that will be needed, review the guidelines below, and consult the Levels of Governance, maintained by the Office of the Provost. The Review and Approval Process is explained below. At the request of the department, Graduate College staff can give advice on such matters. The following may serve as guidelines:

A. Major Revisions

- A change in the credit required for a degree is the one absolute criterion that marks a revision as substantial and requires approval by the Graduate College and report to the Board of Trustees.
- The department has considerable discretion in establishing the curriculum in a particular discipline. The content of graduate courses and graduate programs naturally evolves in response to new directions or emphases in a discipline. A major change in course requirements that substantially changes the content of the degree should be interpreted as a revised program or a new option under an existing degree and requires approval by the Graduate College and subsequent levels of governance. A proposal for a substantially revised program should compare the proposed requirements with those of similar programs at peer institutions.

B. Minor Revisions

- Offering an existing program online or at an off-campus location (at least 50% or more of the degree).
- Credit changed by adding or deleting a requirement for research hours and adding or deleting a requirement for an equal number of hours of course work.
- The department has discretion to revise the course requirements, the sequencing of courses, the requirements and format for master's and doctoral examinations, and the requirements for master's and doctoral theses. Changes in such requirements are generally regarded as minor; however, if the changes are deemed substantial, the unit will be notified that a proposal for revision of a program is required.
- Editorial revisions to the Academic Catalog description of a program.
- Addition or deletion of a comprehensive examination or a qualifying examination.

12.5 Joint Degree Programs

A. Definition

A joint degree program enables a student to earn two degrees with fewer total units of credit than pursuing each degree program separately. The two disciplines being combined should enjoy intellectual synergies, so that the joint degree student acquires knowledge and skills substantially equivalent to a student who takes the programs

separately. If such synergies are not present, then reductions in total requirements could reduce the quality of one or both degrees, and therefore the joint degree proposal would be unlikely to be approved.

The program requirements below make joint degrees different from a dual degree program, in which a student independently chooses to pursue two individual degrees simultaneously.

B. Proposal Requirements

Two academic units that wish to offer a joint degree program must submit a formal proposal for review by the Graduate College. The proposal must include the same elements as a proposal for a new degree program, including the justification for the program, and budgetary and staff implications. The proposal must address the division of tuition revenues and handling of tuition waivers between colleges in which the separate programs are offered. The proposal should explain how students will be advised and evaluated.

C. Program Requirements

- A student who wishes to enter a joint degree program must be admitted separately to each program as a joint degree student.
- Both degrees are awarded simultaneously upon completion of all requirements.
- The joint degree program may share up to 12 credit hours of coursework, but the sum of credit hours for both degrees should not be less than the sum of both degrees less the 12 shared credit hours, unless otherwise approved.
- For all joint degree programs combining a bachelor's degree and master's degree the minimum number of hours required for students is 140 discrete credit hours. This assumes the minimum hours for the bachelor's degree is 120 hours and the minimum hours for the graduate degree is 32 hours, with 12 hours shared by both degrees at the advanced level (400- or 500-level courses).

D. Approval

A joint degree program that combines existing degrees does not require approval beyond the Graduate College and the Office of the Provost; however, joint degree programs must be reported to the Board of Trustees and submitted as part of the university's annual listing to the Illinois Board of Higher Education.

12.6 Online/Off-Campus Programs

A. Curriculum

The requirements for the degree must be the same as the approved on-campus program. The courses required in the program and an adequate number of electives must be offered in the program delivery mode to allow the students to be able to complete the program as approved. Thus, required courses and adequate electives must be offered using the chosen delivery mode in a time period that allows for completion within the Graduate College time limit policies.

B. Student Admission

Graduate College minimum admission requirements are the same for off-campus/online students as they are for their on-campus counterparts (minimum GPA and an earned bachelor's degree from an accredited institution). However, departments may require different application materials of on campus, online and off-campus students if they desire, in order to assess each of those groups for admission purposes. Nevertheless, the overall quality required of an applicant to be admitted must be similar across the programs.

C. Relationship to Existing Programs

Proposals should include how will this new cohort of students be similar to or different from the existing on-campus cohort with regard to the department, the curriculum, and the employment sector, and explain how the new and existing programs interact with each other.

D. Resource Implications

The program must have thoroughly investigated the long-term budget and resource implications of starting an online or off-campus program. The program must be sustainable both in terms of unit budget and staffing of faculty and administrators. Account for potential program growth in this explanation. If special tuition or tuition arrangements are desired, these require additional campus approvals. These approvals should be requested during the proposal process and must be obtained before a program may be implemented.

E. Proposal Process

If a new degree will be created to be offered extramurally or online, the unit should follow the instructions for new degree programs, and the additional reviews needed for extramural/online program review will be included in the approval process. If an existing degree will be offered online or at an off-campus location (at least 50% or more of the degree), units should follow the instructions for revised degree programs. Programs in which instruction will take place outside the U.S. must be reviewed by the Office of International Programs and Studies (to secure needed campus and university approvals).

F. Approval

All programs offered online and off-campus must be reported to the Higher Learning Commission. However additional reports, reviews and approvals may be necessary depending upon the type of program and the location/mode of delivery. Please see the Levels of Governance document maintained by the Office of the Provost.

12.7 Majors, Concentrations, and Minors

Major refers to the student's primary program of study. Students in a graduate major leading to the award of a master's degree are required to complete at least 32 hours, and those in graduate majors leading to the award of a doctoral degree must complete at least 96 hours. See above for more information on these requirements. The successful completion of a major is noted on the student's transcript. Only students in joint or dual degree programs may complete more than one major.

Concentration refers either to a specialized program of study within a major, or an interdisciplinary program. A graduate concentration consists of at least 12 graduate hours of relevant course work. A formal concentration may be defined as an elaboration or an extension of a graduate major: either content specialization within a particular discipline (for example, a taxation concentration in accountancy), or an interdisciplinary program (for example, an interdisciplinary concentration in cultural studies and interpretive research). A concentration is a coherent set of courses some or all of which count toward the major. For more information, see Chapter 4 Graduate Degree and Graduation Requirements.

A **minor** is a coherent set of at least 12 graduate hours of courses defined by one or more units outside the student's enrolling program. A minor encourages and recognizes expertise gained in a particular area. This expertise could be completely outside the usual degree requirements or it could significantly extend knowledge in an area closely related to a particular degree program. For more information, see Chapter 5 Requirements for Master's Degrees, Certificates of Advanced Study, Artist's Diplomas, and Graduate Certificates.

12.8 Options, Tracks, Cognate Field, and Specializations

The terms "track," "cognate field," and "specialization" may have different meanings or may be used interchangeably. While these may be defined within certain units, they may also be created by individual students based upon their own particular interests. Because their successful completion is not noted on the student's transcript, they are less formal than concentrations, and may vary in terms of the hours required. Students may complete more than one option, track, cognate field, or specialization.

12.9 Interdisciplinary Programs

The Graduate College encourages the development of innovative graduate programs, especially interdisciplinary programs. New programs that do not involve new degrees can be developed as options or specializations under existing degree programs. New options do not require review beyond the Graduate College. Interdisciplinary program proposals must have the approval of all cooperating departments, schools, and colleges.

12.10 Guidelines for Multi-Institutional Graduate Degrees in Collaboration with a Foreign Institution

These guidelines can be found on the Senate of the Urbana-Champaign Campus website.

12.11 Review and Approval Process

The Levels of Governance outlines the levels of approval required by program proposal type. Depending upon the proposal type, the approval at each level could require review and a vote, or could be as a listing or consent item.

However, the number of approvals required is commensurate with the significance and extent of the changes proposed. Review the Levels of Governance, on the Provost's Office website, to determine which approvals are required for your proposal.

A. Approvals Before Arrival at the Graduate College

All proposals should have been reviewed and approved by the following units before arriving at the Graduate College:

- Departmental Courses and Curricula Committee or other committee
- Executive Officer
- School (if applicable) Courses and Curricula Committee or other committee
- Director of School (if applicable)
- Disciplinary College Courses and Curricula Committee or other committee
- Dean or designee

B. Committee Review at the Graduate College

Minor revisions. “Minor revisions” to a graduate degree programs, as defined above, are considered for administrative approval by the Graduate College and do not require further committee review. They are reported to the Office of the Provost and the Academic Senate in case any further consideration is needed.

Major revisions. A proposal for a new graduate degree program, or “Major Revisions” to an existing graduate degree program as defined above, require approval by the Graduate College Executive Committee and the dean of the Graduate College.

C. Proposals that Require Approval or Report Beyond the Graduate College

See the Levels of Governance to determine additional levels of review and approval for your particular proposal. The full list of approvals is as follows:

- Provost or designee
- Senate Educational Policy Committee
- Urbana-Champaign Senate Faculty Senate
- Senates Conference
- Board of Trustees
- Illinois Board of Higher Education

Chapter 13
Policy for Graduate Concentrations

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines under which units offering graduate degrees may seek Senate approval of graduate concentrations to be acknowledged on the student's official university transcript.

Background on Graduate Concentrations

The University of Illinois graduate transcript lists **degrees**, **majors**, and **minors** at the graduate level, and all have defined requirements and approval routes. This document defines the requirements for formal graduate concentrations, and the approval route in order for it to be noted on a student's official transcript. A formal concentration may be defined as an elaboration or an extension of a graduate major: either content specialization within a particular discipline (for example, a taxation concentration in accountancy), or an interdisciplinary program (for example, an interdisciplinary concentration in cultural studies and interpretive research). A concentration is a coherent set of courses, some or all of which may count toward the major. In order to be approved and noted on the student's transcript, a graduate concentration requires approval by the disciplinary college, the Graduate College, the Senate, and the Board of Trustees.

This policy seeks to define only those concentrations at the graduate level that would be listed in the Academic Catalog and recorded on the student's official transcript. Although most graduate programs require students to specialize in one form or another, not all of these specializations need to be formal concentrations. Graduate education nearly always involves some form of specialization or interdisciplinary work, yet the need for transcript recognition varies in importance across the disciplines. Indeed, transcript recognition should be sought only when there is a clear benefit to the student and/or to the department—for example, when transcript notation is required by specialized accrediting bodies, or in response to job market demands.

Guidelines for Graduate Concentrations

A graduate concentration must consist of a minimum of 12 graduate hours of coursework at the 400- and 500-level, which gives a student more breadth or depth in their major area of study. Because a concentration is intended to be within the major area of study, the hours required to fulfill the concentration should likewise apply toward completion of the degree. However that is not to say that completion of a concentration within a degree couldn't require more hours than the degree itself, in that the student is earning an additional credential.

- Any academic department or unit with the approval of the disciplinary college(s) may initiate a proposal for a graduate concentration.

- An academic department or unit (or a combination of departments or units, in the case of interdisciplinary programs) intending to propose a concentration should prepare a proposal in accordance with these instructions, including a rationale that indicates why transcript recognition of the concentration is important, and obtain approval(s) from the disciplinary college(s) before sending to the Graduate College.
- The department or unit sponsoring the concentration may set additional prerequisites for eligibility for the concentration (e.g., minimum GPA). Additionally, the sponsoring department or unit may set other requirements for completion, such as a qualifying examination, practicum, and so forth.
- Students must contact the sponsoring department or unit offering the concentration for information about the concentration, and the sponsoring department or unit must make available information and consultation to inform students about requirements for the concentration.
- A student's intent to pursue a graduate concentration must be approved by the student's adviser and graduate program director, as well as the unit offering the concentration. If any credit hours taken toward a concentration will not also count toward the major, that condition must be documented when the student adds the concentration to their academic record so that it can be taken into account at the time of certification of the degree.
- A student who completes a graduate concentration should have at least one faculty member in the area of concentration serve on the student's thesis committee. In the case of interdepartmental concentrations, the thesis committee should comprise faculty members from more than one department or area of knowledge.
- It is up to the sponsoring department or unit to establish criteria and timelines for completion of the concentration, and to certify its successful completion. When a student indicates an intention to graduate with a concentration, the department(s) will confirm whether the requisite course of study has been completed.

Chapter 14
Policy for Graduate Minors

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines under which units may seek Senate approval of a graduate minor to be acknowledged on the student's official university transcript.

Background on Graduate Minors

Graduate programs offer a range of curricular possibilities, including options, tracks, concentrations, specializations, minors, and cognate fields. Graduate minors require approval as described below, and are noted on the student's transcript.

Minors are a coherent set of courses defined by one or more units outside the student's enrolling program. A minor encourages and recognizes expertise gained in a particular area. This expertise could be completely outside the usual degree requirements or it could significantly extend knowledge in an area closely related to, but still outside, a particular degree program. For some students, completing a minor will be both appealing and advisable. The spirit of a minor is the development of additional academic strengths. For this reason, credit used toward the completion of one minor may not be applied toward another minor but it is at the discretion of the major degree department to determine which, if any, of the courses used to fulfill the minor will also be used to fulfill the requirements of the graduate major degree. Some minors may require that a member of the unit(s) offering the minor serve on the student's thesis committee.

Guidelines for Graduate Minors

A minor should constitute a coherent program of study requiring some depth in the subject, but not as extensive a program as the major. The minor should consist of at least 12 graduate hours of course work in the sponsoring department(s). At least 8 to 12 graduate hours of the minor should be courses at the 500-level.

Any academic department or unit with the approval of its disciplinary college may initiate a proposal for a graduate minor. The proposal should comply with the guidelines below and follow the format of the Standard Graduate Minor Approval Form.

- Minors approved by the Graduate College will be forwarded to the Senate for approval.
- All graduate minors must receive disciplinary college, Graduate College, Senate, and Board of Trustees approval in order to be officially recognized by the campus and listed on the transcript.
- The Banner system displays degree, major, concentration, and minor designations. The academic transcript will reflect completion of all Senate-approved graduate minors earned by the student.

- Students must apply to the sponsoring department for admission to the minor. It is up to the sponsoring department to determine the appropriate enrollment, to establish criteria and timelines for admission to the minor.
- A student's application to pursue a graduate minor must also be approved by the student's adviser and graduate program director prior to beginning to fulfill the minor requirements.
- A minor may request that a member of the unit(s) offering the minor serve on the student's master's or doctoral committee.
- The sponsoring department must identify an adviser for each minor. It is the minor adviser's responsibility to advise students on minor requirements.
- When a student indicates an intention to graduate with a minor, the sponsoring department will confirm whether the minor course of study has been completed and certify successful completion of the minor.
- Because of the nature of most graduate programs, master's students generally would not complete more than one minor. Doctoral students generally would not complete more than two minors.

Chapter 15
Graduate Certificates

The Graduate Certificate is a transcripted post-baccalaureate credential designed to allow prospective students the opportunity to enhance their skills and career potential through a coherent set of courses focused on a specific subject in a format that does not require commitment to a full graduate-level degree program.

Admission Requirements for Graduate Certificates

The Graduate Certificate is only available for certificate student enrollment. Applicants must apply for admission to a specific Graduate Certificate program. Admission requirements are set by the academic unit administering the Graduate Certificate program, but must at least meet the campus graduate certificate admissions criteria, which requires a bachelor's degree from a regionally accredited college in the United States or a comparable degree from a recognized institution of higher learning abroad and English proficiency. Individual programs may set admission requirements for GPA, and/or specific prerequisite coursework, though none are specifically required by the Graduate College for Graduate Certificate admission.

Program Requirements for Graduate Certificates

The Graduate Certificate is earned through successful completion of a pre-defined program of graduate-level courses. The program must encompass at least ten weeks of instruction and a total of at least twelve credit hours of graduate-level courses. All courses required by a Graduate Certificate must be at the graduate level, listed at the 400-level or higher. A minimum cumulative GPA of 2.75 is required for awarding of the Graduate Certificate.

No transfer credit from another institution may be used to satisfy the requirements for a Graduate Certificate.

The Graduate Certificate program must be completed within two years of admission to ensure that the course work is current and relevant to the learning outcomes of the program.

Credit hours earned toward a Graduate Certificate may be used, in part or in whole, toward no more than one graduate degree program, at the discretion of the graduate degree program. Admission into a Graduate Certificate program does not imply admission into a graduate degree program. Students completing a Graduate Certificate must apply to and be admitted into a graduate degree program before any credit hours earned through the Graduate Certificate can contribute toward a graduate degree. Per standard policy, completion of a graduate degree program requires enrollment for a minimum of one semester in the graduate degree program as a degree-seeking student.

Graduate Certificates are awarded at the end of each traditional semester (fall, spring, summer) following the campus graduate degree conferral schedule. Students are issued a Certificate Diploma by the Office of the Registrar as well as receiving a credential notation on their transcripts.

Funding Eligibility

Students enrolled as Certificate students are not eligible for waiver-generating graduate assistantships and fellowships unless they have received approval from the Graduate College. Graduate Certificates are intended to be eligible for financial aid. Approval for financial aid will be determined by the Department of Education as a part of the proposal process.

Chapter 16
Policy for the Off-Campus/Online Delivery of Graduate Degree or Certificate Programs

The Graduate College seeks to support units in their efforts to expand and improve off-campus/online educational opportunities and to encourage greater participation by academic units in the lifelong education of nontraditional students, particularly as it relates to continuing professional education. Graduate College policy allows students to satisfy their graduate residence requirement either through courses meeting on campus, online, or through courses that are offered by the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, but meet off-campus. All courses must be approved before they can be offered. See Developing Courses and Programs for the graduate course approval policy and procedure.

While Graduate College policy has expanded access to graduate education, it is also clear that high quality graduate programs often involve more than required courses. Graduate programs often include an independent experience, whether it be professional or research, that challenges the student to examine a topic in detail and draw a unique conclusion. In addition, programs must also involve such elements as a capable and accessible faculty, motivated students, a strong curriculum, competent academic advisement, appropriate and accessible academic facilities, and skilled program administration. Attention to these elements is particularly important in the case of off-campus/online graduate programs because learners may not have as many synchronous interactions with their classmates or the rest of the campus community during their program, as a student residing on campus.

Definition

Graduate degree and certificate programs delivered off-campus/online are those in which more than one-half of the graduate hours required for the degree or certificate completion are offered either online to students at a distance or at off-campus sites.

Authorizations

Authority is vested in the Graduate College for approval of post-baccalaureate (graduate-level) degree and certificate programs.

Graduate programs determine whether or not on-campus graduate students may enroll in the courses they offer online.

All programs offered online and off-campus must be reported to the Illinois Board of Higher Education. However additional reports, reviews and approvals may be necessary depending upon the type of program and the location/mode of delivery as follows:

- **Certificates.** New credit-bearing certificate programs where more than 50 percent of the coursework is not associated with an existing previously approved degree program will require review and approval by the Higher Learning Commission. Certificates offered off-campus/online will require reporting to the Higher Learning Commission.
- **Degree programs.** Any off-campus site-based degree program will require review and approval by the Illinois Board of Higher Education and the Higher Learning Commission prior to enrolling any students. The Office of the Provost will oversee the submission of proposals and reporting of approvals at all levels above the Graduate College.
- **Off-site.** Any new site outside of Illinois where five or more courses are offered must be approved by the Higher Learning Commission. All new sites outside of Illinois must comply with any local or state regulations for delivery of educational programs.
- **Online**. All Title IV-eligible degree or certificate programs where 50 percent or more of the coursework is delivered online or through another means of distance education must be approved in advance by the Higher Learning Commission.

Approval of Off-Campus/Online Graduate Certificate and Degree Programs

Graduate degree and certificate programs offered off-campus/online must be approved by the following units:

- The department, and school, if applicable;
- the academic college;
- the Office of International Programs and Studies (if instruction will take place outside the U.S.) to secure needed campus and university approvals, and;
- the Graduate College;
- the Academic Senate.

Some proposals may need additional reviews.

The Illinois Board of Higher Education and the Higher Learning Commission (the organization that accredits the campus) have complex rules controlling the offering of courses, certificate, and degree programs off-campus or

online. In some cases, the approvals required before any students matriculate in the new program may take as much as a year.

Courses may be offered online or off-campus as part of that program. In most cases, the online or off-campus program will not provide the same variety of courses available to students enrolled in the similar program on-campus. However the courses offered must allow the student to be able to complete the program as approved. Thus required courses and adequate electives must be offered using an equivalent mode of distance delivery and in a time period to allow for completion within the Graduate College time limit policies.

Chapter 17
Graduate Student Annual Academic Progress Reviews

Units must hold annual academic progress reviews for all graduate students.

Campus policy stipulates that graduate units must conduct annual academic progress reviews for all graduate students enrolled in degree-seeking programs at least once every academic year. A written copy of the review must be given to the student and be placed in the student's academic file.

Ideally, academic progress reviews should include the following elements:

- A student self-report and assessment of academic progress
- A review prepared by the adviser and at least one other faculty member to focus on an assessment of degree progress and student strengths and weaknesses. A copy of this written review is given to the student.
- An opportunity for the student to discuss this review in person.

Each program shall annually report to the Graduate College their Annual Progress Review activities. The current Graduate College process for reporting is found on the Graduate College website.